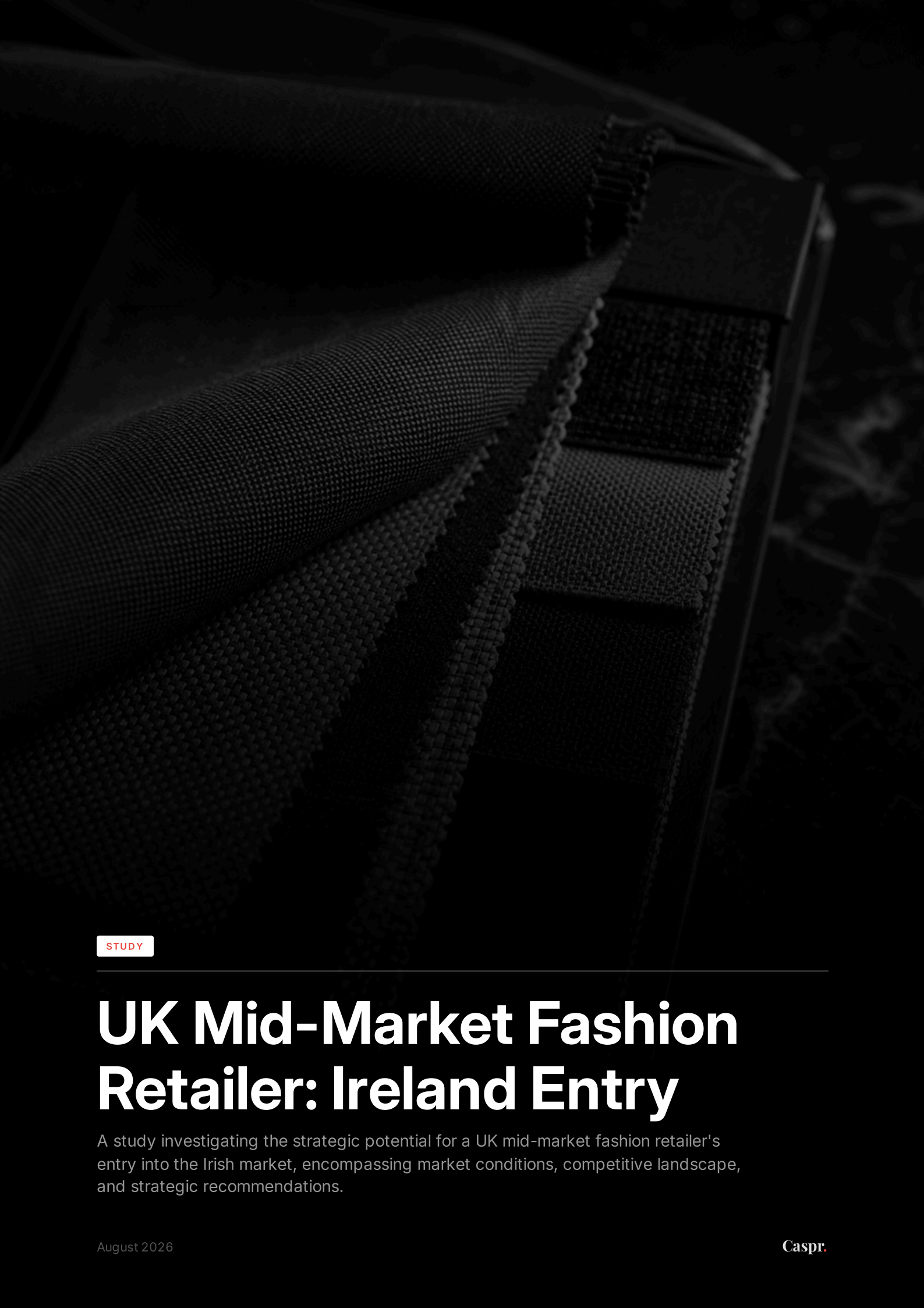




STUDY

UK Mid-Market Fashion Retailer: Ireland Entry

A study investigating the strategic potential for a UK mid-market fashion retailer's entry into the Irish market, encompassing market conditions, competitive landscape, and strategic recommendations.

STUDY REPORT

UK Mid-Market Fashion Retailer: Ireland Entry

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• Executive Summary

Finding 1 — Ireland is a credible first-step expansion market

The report supports Ireland as an entry market for UK mid-market fashion retailers, citing its 5.5 million population, retail growth, and market familiarity for brands such as Next, River Island, and Reiss. It positions Ireland as a practical route to diversify beyond the highly competitive UK market.

Finding 2 — Consumer demand is resilient but value-focused

Ireland's macro backdrop is described as stable, with rising domestic demand and employment supporting the market despite complex GDP signals driven by multinationals. However, consumers are wary of inflationary pressures, so entrants must serve a discerning, value-focused customer with strong quality, service, and price positioning.

Finding 3 — Physical retail remains decisive despite growing digital influence

The fashion market is still dominated by physical stores, even as digital platforms become more important for engagement. The report emphasizes that consumers show an increasing preference for in-store purchasing, making a robust omnichannel model essential rather than a purely online entry.

Finding 4 — Entrenched incumbents raise the bar for new entrants

Established players including Penneys, Dunnes Stores, and TK Maxx benefit from strong customer loyalty and effective omnichannel models. New entrants will need to overcome these embedded relationships by differentiating on quality, service, and execution across both store and digital channels.

Finding 5 — Location strategy is constrained but strategically important

Scarcity of prime retail space in Dublin creates an execution challenge, but also makes the city a valuable flagship location for brand-building. The report recommends Dublin as the initial focal point, with regional towns as phase-two targets and store formats tailored to local demographics.

Finding 6 — Entry should be phased, store-led, and compliance-heavy

The recommended go-to-market model is a conditional market entry built around direct store operations, local e-commerce, and early compliance with Irish and EU rules on supply chains, VAT, and post-Brexit regulation. While financial feasibility is challenged by high entry costs, currency exposure, and occupancy risk, the report still recommends a phased rollout beginning with two flagship stores in Dublin, supported by digital engagement and tight cost management.

1

Introduction and Strategic Context

1

Introduction and Strategic Context

This section frames the Irish market entry question for a UK mid market fashion and apparel retailer operating in the Next, River Island, Reiss, FatFace, and White Stuff tier. The strategic context is that mature UK retailers increasingly rely on a mix of stores, online, and selective internationalisation to sustain growth, diversify earnings, and leverage existing brand, sourcing, and operating capabilities beyond a highly competitive domestic market.^{16 23 22}

Ireland merits evaluation as a first step market because it combines operational familiarity with meaningful commercial scale. Ireland's population reached 5,525,600 in the 12 months to April 2026, retail sales in clothing, footwear and textiles were still growing year on year in mid 2025, and the market remains store led despite a developed digital channel, making it suitable for a measured omnichannel entry model rather than a high risk greenfield international push.^{36 13 14}

1.1

Profile of the UK mid-market fashion and apparel retailer and rationale for international expansion

A typical UK mid market fashion retailer in this peer set has a broad but curated apparel offer, mid tier price architecture, strong brand recognition, and an omnichannel operating model in which stores support acquisition, fulfilment, returns, and brand theatre. Next states that its group mix spans UK retail, UK online, international websites, and third party aggregators, while stores remain important to online collection and returns, illustrating the channel integration expected in this segment.^{16 20}

Typical operating characteristics include the following.

- Product model: Branded own label ranges with seasonal newness, balanced across womenswear, menswear, childrenswear, footwear, and accessories, often with adjacent lifestyle categories to raise basket size and reduce dependence on a single fashion trend cycle.¹⁶
- Channel model: A store estate that doubles as a customer acquisition and service network, supported by e commerce, click and collect, and returns infrastructure.²⁰
- Brand position: More design, quality, and service emphasis than value discounters, but below luxury price points, which is consistent with Reiss describing its platform around design, quality, and customer experience while still pursuing scalable global expansion.²³
- Expansion capability: Existing sourcing, merchandising, and logistics platforms can usually support adjacent markets with lower incremental complexity than entering distant geographies.¹⁶

The rationale for international expansion is primarily strategic rather than opportunistic. UK fashion retail is mature and intensely promotional, so incremental domestic growth is harder to secure without margin pressure; by contrast, nearby international markets allow retailers to spread fixed brand, technology, and supply chain costs across a wider revenue base while reducing concentration risk in one economy.^{16 23}

For this retailer type, international expansion usually serves four goals.

- Growth ambition: Add new revenue pools when domestic store density and online penetration limit easy UK upside.¹⁶

- Asset leverage: Reuse brand equity, buying scale, digital platforms, and fulfilment capabilities in adjacent markets.²⁰
- Risk diversification: Reduce exposure to UK consumer cycles, property cost inflation, and competitive intensity by broadening geographic earnings.^{49 46}
- Capability building: Develop repeatable market entry playbooks before attempting larger continental European opportunities.^{22 12}

Peer behaviour supports this logic. Reiss already operates in Ireland and positions itself as a global brand with 135 stores worldwide including Ireland, while FatFace opened a new store in Westport in February 2025, indicating that Ireland is already viewed by comparable UK brands as a commercially viable extension market rather than a speculative frontier.^{23 22}

1.2

Why Ireland represents a logical first international market for UK fashion brands

Ireland is a logical first international market because it offers a rare combination of adjacency and scale. It is geographically close to the UK, English speaking, culturally familiar in fashion consumption terms, and large enough to support a meaningful test of store, digital, and omnichannel economics, with the population reaching 5,525,600 by April 2026.³⁶

The commercial case is strengthened by resilient domestic demand indicators, even if consumers remain value conscious. Ireland's underlying domestic economy has continued to perform relatively strongly by European standards, with official and bank forecasts pointing to continued growth in modified domestic demand through 2026, while consumer commentary in mid 2026 still described households as concerned and cash constrained rather than structurally retrenching.^{42 48 39}

Ireland also fits the operating model of UK mid market apparel brands.

- Consumer familiarity: UK brands already have awareness spillover through media, tourism, cross border shopping, and existing ecommerce access, lowering brand education costs relative to a non English speaking EU market.^{12 29}
- Omnichannel suitability: The Irish market remains store relevant, while online is established but not dominant. CSO methodology explicitly captures online sales of Irish registered retailers within retail categories, and market commentary in early 2025 showed online turnover easing while core retail and clothing categories improved.^{14 25}
- Demand resilience in apparel: In June 2025, clothing, footwear and textiles recorded 5.9% annual volume growth, showing that the category can still grow despite broader cost of living pressure.¹³
- Manageable complexity: Ireland allows a retailer to learn EU trading, tax, labour, and compliance requirements in a relatively contained market before considering larger and more fragmented continental rollouts.⁴⁶

There is also a strategic sequencing advantage. A successful Irish launch can validate price architecture in euro, test localised assortment and fulfilment, and establish whether the brand can win against strong incumbents without committing immediately to the much higher capital and organisational demands of France, Germany, or Spain.^{22 16}

The main caveat is that Ireland is attractive precisely because it is accessible, which means competition is already well developed. That does not weaken the case for entry, but it means the market should be treated as a disciplined first step market where proposition clarity, location quality, and price perception matter more than simple market presence.^{15 18}

1.3

Report scope, objectives, and how this document should be used by the strategy team

This report is designed as a decision support document for the internal strategy team assessing whether and how to enter Ireland. Its purpose is not only to size the opportunity, but to connect market attractiveness, competitive intensity, property economics, regulatory requirements, and entry mode choices into a practical go or no go recommendation.^{13 46}

The report addresses the following strategic questions.

- Market attractiveness: Is Ireland large, affluent, and resilient enough to justify entry for a UK mid market fashion retailer.^{36 48}
- Category dynamics: Are clothing and footwear demand trends supportive, and how are store and online channels evolving.^{13 14}
- Competitive feasibility: Can a new entrant differentiate against dominant incumbents and established international brands.
- Entry economics: Which locations, formats, and rollout pace can achieve acceptable returns under realistic rent, wage, and demand assumptions.
- Execution risk: What post-Brexit, regulatory, supply chain, and currency issues could impair performance.

The strategy team should use this document in three ways.

- Screening tool: Use the market, consumer, and competitor analysis to decide whether Ireland clears the threshold for active business case development.
- Design tool: Use the location, operating model, and go to market sections to shape the preferred entry format, sequencing, and resource plan.
- Governance tool: Use the financial scenarios, risk assessment, and KPI framework to support executive approval, stage gates, and post launch performance review.

This section therefore sets the baseline assumption for the rest of the study: Ireland should be assessed as a pragmatic, lower complexity, first international market for a UK mid market fashion retailer, but only if the brand can translate UK strengths into a locally credible value proposition. The remainder of the report tests that assumption through macroeconomic, market structure, competitive, property, regulatory, and financial lenses so that the final recommendation is evidence based rather than intuition led.^{22 23 16}

2

Irish Macroeconomic and Consumer Environment

2

Irish Macroeconomic and Consumer Environment

Ireland’s consumer backdrop remains supportive for a measured fashion retail entry, but it is no longer uniformly benign. The domestic economy continued to expand strongly through 2025 on modified domestic demand measures, employment remains near record highs, and household disposable incomes increased in nominal terms, all of which underpin spending capacity even as headline GDP becomes more volatile and less useful for retail planning in 2026 due to multinational distortions and export timing effects.^{46 65 66}

For a UK mid market apparel entrant, the key implication is that Ireland still offers real demand capacity, but consumers are selective and value conscious. Sentiment improved from mid 2026 lows, yet inflation in clothing and footwear, housing, and other essentials is keeping price sensitivity elevated, which favours retailers with clear quality to price positioning, disciplined promotions, and a strong store experience.^{15 46}

2.1

GDP growth, employment levels, and household income trends underpinning retail spending capacity

Ireland’s macro picture should be read through domestic indicators rather than headline GDP alone. The European Commission expects Irish GDP to decline in 2026 because of a base effect from frontloaded pharmaceutical exports in 2025, while domestic demand remains more resilient; its 2026 Country Report states modified domestic demand rose 4.9% in 2025, which is the more relevant signal for discretionary retail.^{46 74}

The labour market remains a core support for apparel demand despite some softening. CSO data for Q2 2026 show employment at 2,839,300, up 21,200 year on year, with an employment rate of 74.3%; unemployment rose to 5.1% from 4.8% a year earlier, but this still represents a relatively tight labour market by European standards.^{81 82 80}

Household incomes are still rising, but not evenly across cohorts. CSO SILC 2025 reports nominal median household disposable income for owner occupied households at EUR 71,338, up 6.8% year on year, while the household sector accounts show gross disposable income increased from EUR 174.8 billion in 2024 to EUR 183.0 billion in 2025, a gain of 4.7%; this supports aggregate spending capacity, but the retail opportunity is strongest where brands can convert income growth into perceived value rather than assume broad based premiumisation.^{66 65}

Title — Ireland consumer spending capacity indicators

INDICATOR	LATEST READING	RETAIL IMPLICATION
Modified domestic demand growth, 2025	4.9%	Healthy domestic demand backdrop for discretionary retail.
Employment, Q2 2026	2,839,300	Large employed consumer base supports apparel volumes.

INDICATOR	LATEST READING	RETAIL IMPLICATION
Unemployment rate, Q2 2026	5.1 %	Slight softening, but still consistent with resilient spending.
Household gross disposable income, 2025	EUR 183.0bn	Aggregate purchasing power continued to expand.
Median disposable income, SILC 2025	EUR 71,338	Mid market price points remain addressable for many households.

Source: 74 81 65 66

2.2

Consumer sentiment, cost-of-living pressures, and price sensitivity in 2025-2026

Consumer conditions in 2025 and 2026 are best described as stable but cautious. The European Commission expects accumulated savings and a resilient labour market to support household spending through the forecast horizon, but this is offset by persistent pressure from essential living costs and a weaker external growth backdrop.⁴⁶

Inflation has re-accelerated enough to keep value perception central to purchase decisions. CSO data show headline CPI rose 3.4% year on year in July 2026, with particularly strong increases in Clothing and Footwear at 8.5% and Housing, Water, Electricity, Gas and Other Fuels at 7.7%; for fashion retail, this means consumers are facing both higher wardrobe prices and higher non-discretionary bills at the same time.^{15 79}

Distributional stress remains visible beneath the aggregate income data. CSO deprivation data show 7.5% of people in 2025 were unable to afford new, not second hand, clothes, up from 6.2% in 2024, indicating that a meaningful minority of households are trading down, delaying replacement purchases, or shifting toward promotions and discount channels.⁶⁹

For a mid market entrant, the practical implication is a bifurcated consumer. Better employed and higher income households can still support full price fashion purchases, but the broader market is likely to reward sharp opening price points, visible promotional cadence, and strong quality signalling more than aspirational pricing alone.^{81 15 69}

2.3

Clothing and footwear spending trends, including the shift back to in-store from online

Clothing and footwear demand has remained positive in Ireland, but channel mix is shifting back toward stores. CSO annual national accounts show personal spending on clothing and footwear increased 6.7% in 2025, while household sector accounts show spending on the category rose 5.7% in the 12 months to December 2025, confirming that apparel remained a growth pocket within consumer expenditure.^{67 65}

Short term retail sales data also support category resilience. The CSO reported that clothing, footwear and textiles volumes were 5.9% higher year on year in June 2025, even as total online retail remained a small share of Irish registered retail turnover at 6.6% excluding motor trades, indicating that physical retail still dominates the market structure relevant to fashion entry.^{13 75}

Market commentary from Lisney's Q1 2025 retail update highlighted the specific channel reversal most relevant to apparel strategy: in store clothing sales rose 2.0% while online clothing sales fell 6.3%. That pattern suggests post pandemic normalisation is favouring tactile, occasion based, and browse led shopping missions in fashion, especially where stores offer fit confidence, immediate fulfilment, and easier returns.²⁵

The implication for entry mode is clear. Ireland should be approached as a store led omnichannel market, not a digital first fashion market, with ecommerce positioned as a support channel for convenience, endless aisle, and retention rather than the primary demand engine at launch.^{13 25}

3

Irish Fashion and Apparel Market Structure

3

Irish Fashion and Apparel Market Structure

Ireland’s fashion market is large enough to support a disciplined mid market entry, but it is structurally concentrated, store led, and increasingly shaped by digital discovery rather than pure online transaction growth. For a UK entrant, the key strategic point is that demand exists across apparel and footwear, yet success depends on winning share in a specialist segment where physical retail still drives most sales and where sustainability, creator commerce, and store experience are becoming more important to conversion and loyalty.^{100 13 121}

3.1

Total market size and value of the apparel and footwear specialist segment in Ireland

Ireland’s total retail market reached about EUR 45.9 billion in 2025, according to Euromonitor’s latest Ireland retail market coverage, confirming that the country offers meaningful scale for a first international move by a UK mid market apparel retailer. Within that market, apparel and footwear specialists remain a distinct and strategically relevant channel, with Euromonitor identifying the segment as a standalone category and reporting continued value growth in 2024, while broader retail also expanded in 2025.^{100 102}

The most reliable public evidence available without paywalled data points is directional rather than fully quantified at subsegment level. Euromonitor’s Ireland specialist report states that apparel and footwear specialists recorded a 2% retail value sales uplift in 2024, indicating a market that is still growing in nominal terms despite consumer caution, but the exact 2025 euro value of the specialist segment is not publicly disclosed in the accessible source material reviewed.^{102 100}

Title — Ireland fashion market structure indicators

INDICATOR	LATEST READING	STRATEGIC IMPLICATION
Total retail market value, 2025	EUR 45.9bn	Sufficient national scale for phased entry.
Apparel and footwear specialists, 2024	Value sales up 2%	Specialist channel still expanding in nominal terms.
Clothing, footwear and textiles retail volume, June 2025 YoY	+5.9%	Category demand remained resilient.
Personal spending on clothing and footwear, 2025	+6.7%	Consumer spend on the category continued to grow.

Source: Caspr analysis.

Growth indicators (% YoY) — ranked by magnitude

Personal spending on clothing & footwear, 2025

+6.7%  +6.7%

Clothing, footwear & textiles retail volume, Jun 2025 YoY

+5.9%  +5.9%

Apparel & footwear specialists value sales, 2024

+2.0%  +2.0%

Market scale (absolute)

Total retail market value, 2025

EUR 45.9bn

● Consumer spend growth ● Volume demand growth ● Specialist channel growth

Source: [100](<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices>) [102](<https://www.marketresearch.com/Euromonitor-International-v746/Apparel-Footwear-Specialists-Ireland-39880004/#:~:text=apparel%20and%20footwear%20specialists,value%20sales%20of%202%25>) [13](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) [67](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-ana/annualnationalaccounts2025/gdpbyexpenditures/personalspending/>) For opportunity sizing, the practical conclusion is that Ireland is not a niche adjacency market but a mid sized national retail market with a still growing apparel spend pool. However, because public sources do not expose a precise 2025 euro value for apparel and footwear specialists, the strategy team should treat the segment as attractive but require paid market data or management estimates before finalising store rollout economics.[100](<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices>) [105](<https://www.marketresearch.com/Euromonitor-International-v746/Retail-Ireland-45637430/#:~:text=Euromonitor%20International%27s%20Retail%20in,developments%20driving%20the%20industry>) ### 3.2. Channel breakdown: physical retail dominance versus e-commerce penetration Ireland remains a physical retail first fashion market, even though online shopping is mainstream. CSO data show online sales accounted for 6.6% of total retail turnover excluding motor trades in June 2025, which is low relative to the visibility of ecommerce in consumer behaviour and reinforces that store based retail still dominates the commercial structure relevant to apparel entry.[13](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) [75](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/backgroundnotes/>) Fashion specific indicators point to the same conclusion. Lisney's Q1 2025 retail market update reported in store clothing sales up 2.0% while online clothing sales fell 6.3%, suggesting that post pandemic channel normalisation is favouring tactile shopping,

immediate fulfilment, and easier fit assurance in stores.[25](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/RetailMarketUpdateQ12025.pdf>) [13]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) That said, ecommerce remains essential as a support channel because Irish consumers are digitally active and fashion is still the most common online purchase category. CSO Household Digital Consumer Behaviour 2025 found that 85% of internet users bought goods or services online, and 70% bought clothes, shoes, or accessories online, although that was down from 77% in 2024, which is consistent with softer online fashion momentum rather than digital disengagement.[101]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issdhdb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/keyfindings/#:~:text=The%20online%20purchases%20of,when%20compared%20with%202024>) [103]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issdhdb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscriptions/#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29>) [104](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issdhdb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2024/#:~:text=shoes%2C%20accessories%20etc.%20,11am%20.%20%2A%20e-Government>)

For entry strategy, this means Ireland should be treated as an omnichannel market where stores do the heavy lifting on brand building and conversion, while ecommerce supports convenience, endless aisle, click and collect, and returns. A digital first launch without physical presence would likely under exploit how Irish consumers currently shop fashion, but a store only model would miss the high level of online browsing and purchasing participation.[101]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issdhdb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/keyfindings/#:~:text=The%20online%20purchases%20of,when%20compared%20with%202024>) [25]

(<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/RetailMarketUpdateQ12025.pdf>)

[100](<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices>) ### 3.3. Emerging trends: sustainability, social commerce (TikTok influence), and experience-led retail Sustainability is moving from brand narrative to operating requirement in Ireland's fashion market. Euromonitor identifies transparency and circularity as reshaping apparel and footwear purchasing, while Irish environmental data show the issue is material: Ireland discards around 110,000 tonnes of textiles annually, with about 64,000 tonnes coming from household waste, and separate textile collection obligations have applied since 1 January 2025 under the revised EU waste framework.[100]

(<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices>) [122](<https://www.epa.ie/our-services/monitoring--assessment/circular-economy/textiles-national-attitudes--behaviours-surveys/#:~:text=The%20fieldwork%20for%20the,fabrics%20and%20car%20upholstery>) [136](https://www.epa.ie/publications/research/current-call-documents/EPA_Research_Call_2025_Technical_Description_v1.1.pdf#:~:text=%7C%20Duration%3A%20%7C%2024,thirds%20of%20Ireland%E2%80%99s%20post-)

For a new entrant, the implication is practical rather than cosmetic. Product traceability, repair or take back propositions, lower waste packaging, and credible fibre or sourcing claims are increasingly relevant because both policy direction and consumer expectations are pushing the market toward circular textiles systems.

[133](https://www.epa.ie/publications/circular-economy/resources/Developing-a-circular-textiles-system-for-Ireland.pdf#:~:text=Commercial%20textile%20recyclers%20also,%28O%2%80%99Leary%20et%20al.%2C%202021%29) [137]
 (https://enterprise.gov.ie/en/publications/publication-files/sustainable-retail-navigating-the-espr.pdf#:~:text=-%20Late%202025%2F2026%20%E2%80%94,ESPR%20measures%20%28textiles%2C%20steel%3F%29) [100](https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices) Social commerce is also becoming more relevant, especially for discovery led categories such as fashion, beauty, and accessories. TikTok Shop launched in Ireland in December 2024, and by May 21, 2026 TikTok said the platform had moved from invite only to open access for all Irish businesses, with Irish creator participation in its affiliate programme up 600%, seller numbers up by triple digits since launch, and more than EUR 2 million in commissions paid to Irish creators.[123](https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktok-shop-in-ireland?from_seo_redirect=1&lang=en-IE#:~:text=Whether%20you%20are%20a,creators%20in%20real%20time) [121]
 (https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE#:~:text=To%20start%20your%20business,Ireland%2C%20sign%20up%20here) This does not mean TikTok Shop is yet a primary route to market for a mid market apparel entrant, but it is becoming an important demand generation and conversion layer. Supporting evidence from recent academic work suggests diversified multi platform social media strategies can lift ecommerce sales by 2% to 5%, which strengthens the case for using TikTok, Instagram, and creator partnerships as part of launch marketing rather than relying on paid performance media alone.[96]
 (https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent) [101](https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/keyfindings/#:~:text=The%20online%20purchases%20of,when%20compared%20with%202024) Experience led retail is the third structural trend. Euromonitor highlights flagship refreshes and lifestyle oriented concepts such as Penneys' experiential upgrades and Arket's first Irish store as evidence that stores are being used to create dwell time, brand theatre, and loyalty rather than just transact stock.[100](https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices) For a UK mid market entrant, the strategic read across is clear. - Sustainability: Must be visible in proposition design, not confined to CSR reporting. - Social commerce: Best used for discovery, creator advocacy, and event driven drops rather than as the sole sales engine. - Experience led retail: Store design, service, and local events matter because physical retail remains the dominant channel and increasingly needs to justify the trip.[100]
 (https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,Entrants%20Reshape%20Consumer%20Choices) [121]
 (https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE#:~:text=To%20start%20your%20business,Ireland%2C%20sign%20up%20here) [122](https://www.epa.ie/our-services/monitoring--assessment/circular-economy/textiles-national-attitudes--behaviours-surveys/#:~:text=The%20fieldwork%20for%20the,fabrics%20and%20car%20upholstery) ## 4. Competitive Landscape Ireland's apparel and footwear specialist market is highly concentrated, with Penneys, Dunnes Stores and TK Maxx accounting for

roughly two thirds of value sales in 2025. The competitive set is therefore difficult to attack on price alone, because the leaders already span value fashion, grocery linked convenience, and off price branded treasure hunt missions at national scale.

[152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) [153]

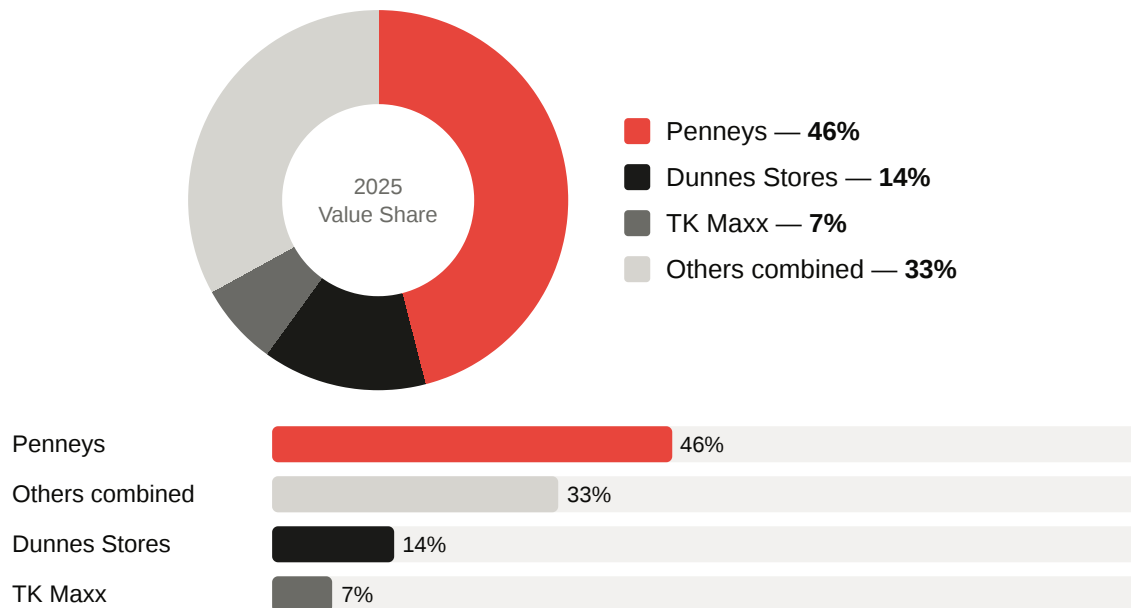
(<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/#:~:text=New%20accounts%20filed%20by,prior%2053%20week%20period>)

For a UK mid market entrant, the more realistic route is to avoid direct confrontation with Penneys on opening price and instead target the under served space between value and premium. That space favours retailers that combine dependable quality, clearer fit and styling authority, stronger omnichannel execution, and a more polished store environment than the dominant value players, while remaining more accessible than luxury or designer led operators.[152]

(<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) [190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=Wed%20Apr%2001%202026,%E2%80%A2%204%20MIN%20READ>) ### 4.1. Dominant players: Penneys (46% value share), Dunnes Stores (14%), TK Maxx (7%) and their mid-market positioning Euromonitor states that apparel and footwear specialists in Ireland were highly concentrated in 2025, with Penneys on 46% value share, Dunnes Stores on 14%, and TK Maxx on 7% [152]

(<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) This concentration means any entrant is competing against incumbents with entrenched customer habits, broad national store coverage, and strong value perception. Title: Leading apparel specialists in Ireland | Retailer | 2025 value share | Strategic position | |---|---|:---| | Penneys | 46% | Dominant value fashion anchor with national scale and very strong price perception. | | Dunnes Stores | 14% | Mixed retailer using grocery footfall and own brand fashion to capture family spend. | | TK Maxx | 7% | Off price branded model focused on deal discovery and margin through opportunistic buying. | | Others combined | 33% | Fragmented long tail including international chains and smaller specialists. |



Source: [152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) Penneys remains the reference point for value fashion in Ireland, but recent filings show some softness beneath that dominance. Irish sales fell from EUR 741.7 million to EUR 729.6 million in the year to September 2025, marking a second consecutive annual decline, even as the business continued to invest in stores and proposition upgrades.[156] (<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2026/07/27/primark-profits-surge-to-14bn-as-penneys-sales-decline-for-second-year/#:~:text=The%20partnership%20opened%20its,in%20Dubai%20this%20year>) [158](<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2025/07/18/penneys-irish-parent-profits-top-2m-per-day-last-year/#:~:text=Primark%20Way%20franchise%20income,from%20Irish%20retail%20revenues>) Penneys' response has been to defend leadership through reinvestment rather than retrenchment. The company reaffirmed a EUR 250 million 10 year Irish investment plan, completed a EUR 5 million refurbishment of its O'Connell Street flagship, invested EUR 7 million to double the size of its Dooradoyle store, and launched its July 20, 2026 "Iconic Value" campaign to lower prices across hundreds of core lines while also stressing better quality, fit and style.[168] (<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/dooradoyle-opens-its-doors-to-more-penneys-doubles-in-size-following-7-million-investment#:~:text=Fintan%20Costello%2C%20Head%20of,completely%20transformed%20shopping%20space>) [171](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/penneys-o-connell-street-gets-a-5-million-makeover#:~:text=%E2%80%9CWe%20are%20delighted%20to,its%20O%E2%80%99Connell%20Street%20store>) [166](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites#:~:text=accompanied%20by%20continued%20improvements,feel%20good%20for%20less>) The implication is that Penneys is moving to close the classic mid market attack line of "better style at similar value". A new entrant should assume Penneys will remain highly aggressive on visible opening price points, basics, kidswear, and high traffic city centre and shopping centre locations, but its scale model still leaves room above pure value on fabric quality, fit consistency, service,

and curated lifestyle presentation.[166](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites#:~:text=accompanied%20by%20continued%20improvements,feel%20good%20for%20less>) [152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) Dunnes Stores is structurally different because fashion is embedded inside a broader grocery led mixed retail model. That gives it frequent customer traffic, strong family shopping missions, and the ability to cross subsidise apparel visibility through vouchers, food trips, and destination stores, which is difficult for a standalone entrant to replicate.[100]

(<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Chart%207%20Forecast%20Value%20Sales%20by%20Category%202025-2030>) [162]

(https://www.bordbia.ie/globalassets/bordbia.ie/about/governance/foi-disclosure-log/2025_irelandroigroceryretailreport.pdf#:~:text=It%20is%20a%20family-run,to%20January%2026th%2C%202025%29) Its fashion proposition sits in the practical middle of the market rather than in trend led fashion leadership. Dunnes is strongest where customers want acceptable style, trusted basics, childrenswear, and convenience in one trip, so a UK entrant should not try to out convenience Dunnes but instead out edit it through sharper brand handwriting, better category authority, and a more inspiring store environment.[152]

(<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) [162]

(https://www.bordbia.ie/globalassets/bordbia.ie/about/governance/foi-disclosure-log/2025_irelandroigroceryretailreport.pdf#:~:text=It%20is%20a%20family-run,to%20January%2026th%2C%202025%29) TK Maxx occupies a third position that is not directly mid market but still competes for discretionary fashion spend. RTÉ reported that TJX Ireland UC increased revenue 1.6% to EUR 234.18 million and pre tax profit to EUR 10.13 million in the year to February 1, 2025, while continuing to trade on branded merchandise at 20% to 60% below full price comparables.[153](<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/#:~:text=New%20accounts%20filed%20by,prior%2053%20week%20period>)

Financially, TK Maxx appears healthy and operationally resilient, but its proposition is episodic rather than wardrobe building. That creates a useful distinction for a UK entrant: customers may visit TK Maxx for opportunistic branded bargains, yet still lack a reliable destination for coordinated, good quality, mid priced fashion with predictable sizing, replenishment, and omnichannel service.[153]

(<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/#:~:text=New%20accounts%20filed%20by,prior%2053%20week%20period>)

[152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) ### 4.2. International fashion retailers operating in Ireland (Zara, Next, Monsoon) and their strategies Among international operators, Zara is the clearest example of a retailer doubling down on physical scale and flagship quality in Ireland. Its official Irish store locator shows one store in Cork and four in Dublin, while Hammerson and The Irish Times report that Zara is expanding its Dundrum Town Centre store by 43% from 26,300 sq ft to 37,700 sq ft, with

completion due in late 2026, alongside a first standalone Zara Home in Ireland at Dundrum.[186](<https://www.zara.com/ie/en/z-stores-st1404.html?v1=11108#:~:text=%23%20Store%20locator%20,.%20%23%23%23%20DUBLIN%20%284%29>) [185](<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2025/04/29/zara-and-pullbear-to-expand-dundrum-town-centre-presence/#:~:text=Zara%20is%20set%20to,refurbish%20its%20existing%20store>) [191](<https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/hammerson-signs-irelands-first-ever-zara-home-dundrum-town#:~:text=The%20new%20store%20comes,late%20in%20winter%202026>) Zara is also linked to a much larger Henry Street presence, with market commentary indicating that the reopened store is expected to be among the largest in Ireland and potentially the largest Zara in the market. The strategic message is clear: Inditex sees Ireland as capable of supporting fewer, larger, more productive stores that blend flagship presentation with omnichannel convenience rather than a dense network of smaller units.[192](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2025/12/03/dublin-city-centre-remains-destination-of-choice-for-international-retailers/#:~:text=Dylan%20Oaks%20and%20Austen,early%20in%20the%20year>) [195](<https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-June-2025-re1.pdf#:~:text=Zara%20for%20instance%20has,98.9%25%20%7C%2094.0%25%20%7C>) [193](<https://www.origincapital.ie/7th-july-issue-554/#:~:text=also%20owned%20by%20Ashley%2C,the%20south%20of%20Ireland>) For a UK entrant, Zara raises the bar on fashion credibility, visual merchandising, and store design in prime locations. However, Zara's model is more trend led and urban than the typical UK mid market family lifestyle retailer, which leaves room for a proposition built around wearability, broader age appeal, and less fashion risk. [185](<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2025/04/29/zara-and-pullbear-to-expand-dundrum-town-centre-presence/#:~:text=Zara%20is%20set%20to,refurbish%20its%20existing%20store>) [189](<https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/wave-new-openings-and-brand-investments-dundrum-town-centre#:~:text=These%20build%20on%20the,was%20also%20recently%20upgraded>) Next is already a meaningful benchmark because it demonstrates that a UK mid market model can operate at scale in Ireland. Next's Irish store locator lists stores across Dublin, Cork, Athlone, Carlow, Castlebar and other regional locations, while RTÉ reported in July 2025 that Next had around 460 stores across the UK and Ireland and online operations in more than 70 countries.[208](<https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator/#:~:text=Ireland%20%23%20STORE%20LOCATOR%20%23%23%23%20Transform%20your%20wardrobe>) [197](<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0731/1526253-next-quarterly-results/#:~:text=Next%20has%20around%20460,than%20700%20other%20brands>) [198](<https://www.nextplc.co.uk/~media/Files/N/next-plc-v4/about-next/annual-report-and-accounts-jan-2026.pdf#:~:text=Dhaka%20Mymensingh%20Road%2C%20Uttara,1230%20Bangladesh%3C%2Ftd%3E%3Ctd%3E100%3C%2Ftd%3E%3Ctd%3EIndirect%20%28gross%20interest%29%3C%2Ftd%3E%3C%2Ftr%3E>) Next's strategy in Ireland appears to be broad based omnichannel accessibility rather than a pure flagship play. Its estate spans city, shopping centre and retail park formats, and its wider group model integrates stores with online fulfilment, returns and multi brand assortment, which is a strong proof point that Irish consumers will support a dependable, service led, mid market proposition if it is executed consistently.[208]

(<https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator#:~:text=Ireland%20%23%20STORE%20LOCATOR%20%23%23%23%20Transform%20your%20wardrobe>) [198]

(<https://www.nextplc.co.uk/~media/Files/N/next-plc-v4/about-next/annual-report-and-accounts-jan-2026.pdf#:~:text=Dhaka%20Mymensingh%20Road%2C%20Uttara,1230%20Bangladesh%3C%2Ftd%3E%3Ctd%3E100%3C%2Ftd%3E%3Ctd%3EIndirect%20%28group%20interest%29%3C%2Ftd%3E%3C%2Ftr%3E>) Monsoon is a smaller but still relevant comparator because it illustrates both opportunity and fragility for specialist international entrants. Monsoon's Irish store finder currently shows a limited physical presence, while The Irish Times reported Monsoon Accessorize among brands opening on Henry Street in 2025, suggesting a selective re entry or repositioning around high footfall urban locations rather than broad national rollout. [210](<https://www.monsoonlondon.com/ie/stores/?country=IE#:~:text=%23%20Store%20finder%20.,%2A%20MONSOON%20ACCESSORIZE%20SLIGO>) [192](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2025/12/03/dublin-city-centre-remains-destination-of-choice-for-international-retailers/#:~:text=Dylan%20Oaks%20and%20Austen,early%20in%20the%20year>) The lesson from Monsoon is that niche international brands can still find space in Ireland, but usually through focused location choices and differentiated product authority rather than scale economics. For a new UK entrant, that supports a phased model starting with a small number of high quality stores and strong digital integration, not a rapid national rollout.[210]

(<https://www.monsoonlondon.com/ie/stores/?country=IE#:~:text=%23%20Store%20finder%20.,%2A%20MONSOON%20ACCESSORIZE%20SLIGO>) [192](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2025/12/03/dublin-city-centre-remains-destination-of-choice-for-international-retailers/#:~:text=Dylan%20Oaks%20and%20Austen,early%20in%20the%20year>)

4.3. Whitespace and differentiation opportunities for a new UK mid-market entrant The main whitespace is not at the bottom of the market, where Penneys is overwhelmingly strong, nor at the highly trend led end, where Zara has strong brand authority. It sits in the broad middle where Irish consumers want better quality, more dependable fit, and a more enjoyable shopping experience than value chains offer, but remain price sensitive and unwilling to trade up to premium designer price points.[152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) [156]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2026/07/27/primark-profits-surge-to-14bn-as-penneys-sales-decline-for-second-year/#:~:text=The%20partnership%20opened%20its,in%20Dubai%20this%20year>) [185](<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2025/04/29/zara-and-pullbear-to-expand-dundrum-town-centre-presence/#:~:text=Zara%20is%20set%20to,refurbish%20its%20existing%20store>) Three gaps are especially actionable. - Quality to price gap: Penneys is reinforcing value, but its scale and price architecture still make it harder to own a message around superior fabric, longevity, and fit consistency at moderate price premiums. [166](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites#:~:text=accompanied%20by%20continued%20improvements,feel%20go>)

od%20for%20less) [152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) - Lifestyle curation gap: Dunnes is convenient and TK Maxx is opportunistic, but neither fully owns a polished, coordinated wardrobe and home adjacencies proposition in the way stronger UK mid market retailers can.[153] (<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/#:~:text=New%20accounts%20filed%20by,prior%2053%20week%20period>) [162](https://www.bordbia.ie/globalassets/bordbia.ie/about/governance/foi-disclosure-log/2025_irelandroigroceryretailreport.pdf#:~:text=It%20is%20a%20family-run,to%20January%2026th%2C%202025%29) - Omnichannel service gap: Ireland is store led but digitally active, so there is room for a retailer that makes click and collect, returns, stock visibility, and cross channel shopping materially easier than many incumbents do today.[208](<https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator#:~:text=Ireland%20%23%20STORE%20LOCATOR%20%23%23%23%20Transform%20your%20wardrobe>) [101] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/keyfindings/>) A new entrant should therefore position around “affordable confidence” rather than “cheap fashion”. That means opening price points must remain credible, but the lead message should be better made everyday fashion, clearer outfitting, and lower purchase risk through fit, service and returns, which is harder for Penneys and TK Maxx to replicate structurally.[166](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites#:~:text=accompanied%20by%20continued%20improvements,feel%20good%20for%20less>) [153](<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/#:~:text=New%20accounts%20filed%20by,prior%2053%20week%20period>) Category wise, the best entry wedges are likely to be womenswear, occasion and smart casual, family outfitting with stronger quality cues, and lifestyle adjacencies such as footwear, accessories and selected home. These are categories where Zara can be too trend led, Penneys too value led, and TK Maxx too inconsistent, creating room for a retailer with a stable, edited assortment and dependable replenishment.[185](<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2025/04/29/zara-and-pullbear-to-expand-dundrum-town-centre-presence/#:~:text=Zara%20is%20set%20to,refurbish%20its%20existing%20store>) [152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,industry%20and%20geographic%20specialisation>) Location strategy should reinforce that differentiation. Rather than taking secondary space and competing on rent, a UK entrant should prioritise a small number of high visibility stores in prime city or dominant shopping centre locations where store environment, service and omnichannel collection can signal a step up from value retail, while avoiding direct adjacency to Penneys where possible unless the site economics and footfall are exceptional.[190] (<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=Wed%20Apr%2001%202026,%E2%80%A2%204%20MIN%20READ>) [189](<https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/wave-new-openings-and-brand-investments-dundrum-town->

[illegible]

catchments, and larger unit availability. Dundrum Town Centre remains the strongest single suburban fashion destination, with Hammerson reporting 9.6 million annual footfall in 2025 on its portfolio page and ongoing brand investment in 2026, while Dundrum's own site says it welcomes over 15 million visitors a year, indicating very high traffic even if operator-reported figures differ by methodology.[263] (<https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio#:~:text=Image%3A%202026%20Half%20Year,acquisition%20of%20Manchester%20Arndale>) [272] (<https://www.dundrum.ie/about-us#:~:text=With%20more%20than%2040,something%20new%20to%20discover>) [189] (<https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/wave-new-openings-and-brand-investments-dundrum-town-centre#:~:text=ongoing%20investment%20and%20an,in%202026%20and%20beyond.%22>) Other major suburban centres also matter because they offer scale without city-centre occupancy cost. Blanchardstown Centre draws about 17 million annual visits according to RTÉ, and Bannon notes that Dublin's five major shopping centres together can attract close to two million visits in a single week during peak trading periods, underlining the depth of suburban demand.[265] (<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0204/1494676-falcon-am-to-be-bought-by-strategic-value-partners/#:~:text=He%20began%20his%20tenure,as%20Falcon%20Asset%20Management>) [260] (<https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market>) Cork is the strongest regional city for a second-wave opening because it combines city-centre visibility with a broad metropolitan catchment. Patrick Street remains the prime high street, and current letting brochures from Cushman & Wakefield describe 26 Patrick Street and 65 St Patrick's Street as prime, high-profile city-centre opportunities, indicating that quality fashion space is actively being marketed even if public benchmark rent data are less transparent than in Dublin.[288] (https://property.cushmanwakefield.ie/storage/opportunities/November2025/24CORINV0059_26%20Patrick%20St%20%26%2019%20Winthrop%20Letting%20Brochure.pdf#:~:text=Prime%20retail%20opportunity%20in,city%20centre%20with%20profile) [297] (<https://property.cushmanwakefield.ie/storage/opportunities/January2025/24CORRET0009%20-%2065%20Patrick%20Street.pdf#:~:text=T%3A%20353%20%280%2987%20315%207836>) Galway is attractive for brand awareness and tourism-led trading, but it should be approached selectively because the city centre is smaller and more seasonal than Dublin or Cork. The National Transport Authority's Galway shopper survey confirms the strength of the city-centre retail core and its broad access by sustainable transport, while Galway City Council continues to prioritise public-realm and tourism measures intended to support retail vibrancy and future footfall.[266] (<https://www.nationaltransport.ie/publications/nta-galway-shopper-survey/#:~:text=This%20newly%20published%20report,using%20sustainable%20transport%20modes>) [274] (<https://www.galwaycity.ie/news/2025/galway-city-council-and-latin-quarter-support-continued-vibrancy-and-liveability-of#:~:text=and%20the%20forthcoming%20shop%20front%20enhancement%20scheme.%E2%80%9D>) Limerick and selected regional towns should be treated as later-stage opportunities rather than first-entry priorities. Crescent Shopping Centre remains the dominant organised retail destination in the mid-west with about 90 stores and 37,000 sq m of retail space, making it more attractive than weaker traditional city-centre pitches for a mid-market apparel format, while towns such as Athlone, Castlebar, Carlow, and Westport are better suited once the brand has

proven Irish store economics and omnichannel support.[298]
<https://crescentshoppingcentre.ie/commercial-opportunities/#:~:text=Crescent%20Shopping%20Centre%20opened,mid%20west%20of%20Ireland>) [208](<https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator>) ### 5.2. Rental benchmarks, lease structures, and space availability across formats Prime rent benchmarks are clearest in Dublin and should anchor underwriting assumptions. Grafton Street was stabilising at about EUR 5,380 per sq m by 2025, with a recent Levi's letting setting a new benchmark of EUR 5,810 per sq m, while Lisney and Bannon both point to upward pressure on rents because demand is outstripping supply in prime and well-located mid-sized units.[190]
<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafton-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=There%20have%20been%2025,and%20Seasons%20of%20Ireland>) [247](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/Outlook2026-6.pdf#:~:text=Yet%20perhaps%20surprisingly%20in,to%20continue%20in%202026>) [260](<https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market>) Outside Dublin, public rent transparency is weaker, so the strategy team should use city-specific quoting evidence and the Commercial Leases Register rather than rely on generic headline estimates. Cushman & Wakefield brochures confirm active prime availability on Cork's Patrick Street, and Cushman & Wakefield's Ireland Retail Marketbeat Q2 2025 lists Galway Shop Street among tracked prime retail pitches, but neither source provides a simple public benchmark equivalent to Grafton Street in the accessible material reviewed.[288]
https://property.cushmanwakefield.ie/storage/opportunities/November2025/24CORI NV0059_26%20Patrick%20St%20%26%2019%20Winthrop%20Letting%20Brochure.pdf#:~:text=Prime%20retail%20opportunity%20in,city%20centre%20with%20profile) [280](https://assets.cushmanwakefield.com/-/media/cw/marketbeat-pdfs/2025/q2/emea/ireland-retail-marketbeat_q2-2025.pdf?rev=340cf2f1cda64f8e82974126e1671084#:~:text=The%20second%20quarter%20has,earlier%20in%20the%20year) Lease structures in Ireland remain negotiable, but the market is becoming less tenant-friendly than immediately after 2020. Lisney expects lease terms to harden gradually in 2026, although some post-2020 flexibility remains, and the PSRA Commercial Leases Register shows that Irish lease filings capture term, rent, commencement date, rent review frequency, break clauses, service charges, repairs, and rent-free periods, which makes it a practical benchmarking tool for live deal comparison.[247](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/Outlook2026-6.pdf#:~:text=Yet%20perhaps%20surprisingly%20in,to%20continue%20in%202026>) [285](<https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/#:~:text=Commercial%20Leases%20Register%20PSRA,Commercial%20Lease%20Register%20Information>) [291](<https://data.gov.ie/ga/dataset/dublin-commercial-lease-register/resource/386016df-3224-4365-b73b-7499a7a86f60#:~:text=Fitting-out%20Time%2C%20Fit-out%20Allowances,Clause%20in%20the%20Lease>) Modern Irish commercial leases commonly include periodic rent review rather than fixed annual uplifts alone. The Law Reform consolidation of the Property Services Regulation Act confirms that lease records include term and rent, while the Society of Chartered Surveyors Ireland notes that modern business leases typically allow rent to move either upward or downward to market at review, which is important for underwriting downside protection as well as future occupancy cost risk.[287]
<https://revisedacts.lawreform.ie/eli/2011/act/40/section/87/revised/en/html#:~:text=>

%282%29%20The%20Commercial%20Leases,respect%20of%20the%20property%20C) [300](https://scsi.ie/rent-reviews/#:~:text=Rent%20review%20clauses%20in,the%20determined%20market%20rent) Space availability is tightest in prime high street and dominant shopping-centre formats, especially for mid-sized fashion boxes. Bannon reports exceptionally strong demand for well-located, mid-sized retail accommodation following the release of former New Look, Argos, Euro Giant, and Born units, and notes that some landlords used best-bid processes because interest was so strong.[260] (https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market) The practical implication is to match format to market rather than chase a single prototype. A 3,000 to 6,000 sq ft store is more realistic for prime city-centre and regional high-street entry, while 6,000 to 12,000 sq ft works better in dominant suburban centres where adjacencies, parking, and family shopping missions support broader assortment and higher basket size; this format guidance is an inference from current Irish availability patterns, centre competition for larger boxes, and the observed expansion of brands such as Zara in Dundrum.[189] (https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/wave-new-openings-and-brand-investments-dundrum-town-centre#:~:text=ongoing%20investment%20and%20an,in%202026%20and%20beyond.%22) [262](https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-September-2025.pdf#:~:text=L23%40P1%3A%20Recent%20arrivals%20such,transforming%20the%20leisure%20scene) Title: Indicative retail location economics | Location format | Public benchmark or evidence | Strategic use | |---|---|---| | Dublin Grafton Street | EUR 5,380 to EUR 5,810 per sq m prime rent | Flagship, brand theatre, tourism, full-price positioning. | | Dublin dominant suburban centres | High demand, limited supply, rents under upward pressure | Core rollout format for family and omnichannel trading. | | Cork prime city centre | Prime Patrick Street units actively marketed | Second-wave regional city entry with lower occupancy cost than Dublin. | | Galway and Limerick dominant pitches | Selective availability, smaller scale catchments | Opportunistic phase-two or phase-three openings. | Source: [190] (https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafton-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=There%20have%20been%2025,and%20Seasons%20of%20Ireland) [247](https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/Outlook2026-6.pdf#:~:text=Yet%20perhaps%20surprisingly%20in,to%20continue%20in%202026) [260](https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market) [288] (https://property.cushmanwakefield.ie/storage/opportunities/November2025/24CORI NV0059_26%20Patrick%20St%20%26%2019%20Winthrop%20Letting%20Brochure.pdf#:~:text=Prime%20retail%20opportunity%20in,city%20centre%20with%20profile) ### 5.3. Footfall data, catchment demographics, and site selection criteria Footfall remains the first screening variable because Ireland's fashion market is still store-led and prime locations are winning share. Grafton Street exceeded 42 million visits in 2025, Bannon reported high-street footfall in May 2026 was 2.9% ahead of May 2025, and shopping-centre footfall in May 2026 was 0.95% ahead year on year, showing that both city-centre and organised retail formats remain active despite online maturity.[190](https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafton-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-

2020/#:~:text=There%20have%20been%2025,and%20Seasons%20of%20Ireland)
 [260](https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market)
 Catchment quality matters as much as raw traffic. Academic retail location research consistently finds that store performance is best explained by a combination of human flow, nearby place mix, and demographic fit rather than footfall alone, and shopping-mall attraction research shows that mall choice is strongly shaped by distance, mall size, and surrounding population distribution, which is directly relevant to suburban-centre selection in Ireland.[231]
 (https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378#:~:text=Title%3A%20Massive%20Retail%20Location,introducing%20an%20alternative%20approach) [240]
 (https://arxiv.org/abs/1306.1704#:~:text=Traditional%20approaches%20to%20the,nearby%20or%20remote%20areas) [241]
 (https://arxiv.org/abs/1802.00041#:~:text=The%20social%20inclusion%20aspects,discussed%20in%20the%20literature) For a UK mid-market fashion retailer, the most attractive Irish catchments are affluent or upper-middle suburban family zones, dense urban professional districts, and regional city centres with strong tourism and student overlays. Bannon estimates the Greater Dublin Area population at about 2.1 million, and the concentration of visits across Dublin's major centres indicates that suburban Dublin offers the deepest repeatable catchment for multi-store rollout.
 [260](https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market)
 Galway and Cork require a slightly different lens because tourism, hospitality, and student demand can materially influence trading patterns. Galway's city-centre shopper survey and public-realm investment agenda suggest a compact but resilient core with strong non-car access, while Cork's prime city-centre stock on Patrick Street remains the focal point for fashion visibility and regional draw.[266]
 (https://www.nationaltransport.ie/publications/nta-galway-shopper-survey/#:~:text=This%20newly%20published%20report,using%20sustainable%20transport%20modes) [297]
 (https://property.cushmanwakefield.ie/storage/opportunities/January2025/24CORRETO009%20-%2065%20Patrick%20Street.pdf#:~:text=T%3A%20353%20%280%2987%20315%207836) Recommended site selection criteria should be applied in a strict hierarchy.
 - Catchment fit: Prioritise locations with strong concentrations of 25 to 54 year old consumers, family households, and above-average disposable income, because this is the core demand pool for mid-market apparel. This demographic emphasis is an inference from the target retailer profile and from retail location literature showing the importance of demographic-product fit.[230]
 (https://arxiv.org/abs/0912.3982#:~:text=The%20work%20presents%20a,for%20a%20new%20location) [240]
 (https://arxiv.org/abs/1306.1704#:~:text=Traditional%20approaches%20to%20the,nearby%20or%20remote%20areas) - Footfall quality: Focus on intent-driven fashion traffic, not just absolute volume. Grafton Street's recovery and continued retailer expansion suggest that motivated shoppers matter more than passive passers-by.
 [190](https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=There%20have%20been%2025,and%20Seasons%20of%20Ireland) - Adjacency mix: Seek co-tenancy with Zara, Next, M&S, JD Sports, Boots, and strong food anchors rather than direct clustering beside Penneys where possible. This supports cross-shopping while reducing direct value comparison pressure.[189]
 (https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/wave-new-openings-and-brand-

investments-dundrum-town-centre#:~:text=ongoing%20investment%20and%20an,in%202026%20and%20beyond.%22) [208](https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator) - Unit economics: Require occupancy cost to sales ratios that remain viable under conservative sales densities, especially in Dublin where rent inflation risk is highest. Tight supply and best-bid processes mean discipline on target rent and fit-out contribution is essential.[260](https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf#:~:text=A%20similar%20trend%20has,back%20to%20the%20market) - Access and convenience: In suburban centres, parking, public transport, and ease of returns are critical. In city centres, visibility, frontage, and tourist flow matter more. [265](https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0204/1494676-falcon-am-to-be-bought-by-strategic-value-partners/#:~:text=He%20began%20his%20tenure,as%20Falcon%20Asset%20Management) [266](https://www.nationaltransport.ie/publications/nta-galway-shopper-survey/#:~:text=This%20newly%20published%20report,using%20sustainable%20transport%20modes) The recommended entry sequence is therefore clear. Start with one Dublin flagship in the Grafton Street catchment or a near-prime south city-centre alternative if economics are superior, then add one or two dominant suburban-centre stores in Dundrum and either Blanchardstown or Liffey Valley, before moving to Cork and then Galway or Limerick once Irish sales densities, returns behaviour, and local marketing efficiency are proven.[190] (https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=There%20have%20been%2025,and%20Seasons%20of%20Ireland) [263] (https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio#:~:text=Image%3A%202026%20Half%20Year,acquisition%20of%20Manchester%20Arndale) [265] (https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0204/1494676-falcon-am-to-be-bought-by-strategic-value-partners/#:~:text=He%20began%20his%20tenure,as%20Falcon%20Asset%20Management) ## 6. Regulatory, Legal, and Post-Brexit Trade Considerations Ireland is a relatively accessible first EU market for a UK fashion retailer, but post-Brexit it is no longer a low-friction extension of the UK domestic operating model. Entry requires the business to comply simultaneously with Irish retail law, directly applicable EU product and consumer rules, EU customs and VAT procedures for goods moving from Great Britain, and Irish employment, data protection, and property compliance obligations.[323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en#:~:text=The%20EU-UK%20Trade%20and,and%20rules%20of%20origin) [318] (https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities) [354](https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/individuals/data-protection-basics#:~:text=It%20also%20sets%20out,principles%20underlying%20data%20protection) The strategic implication is that Ireland remains operationally manageable, but only if the retailer localises its legal and supply chain setup early. The main execution risks are not market access barriers in the classic sense, but origin compliance, customs administration, VAT treatment, product information accuracy, consumer law compliance, and the cost of running an Irish entity or branch to Irish employment and planning standards.[321] (https://webgate.acceptance.ec.europa.eu/portal9/en/content/eu-uk-trade-and-cooperation-

agreement#:~:text=Such%20rules%20are%20mostly,not%20exceed%20%E2%82%AC6%20000) [343](https://www.ccpc.ie/information-for-businesses/selling-goods-and-services/selling-products#:~:text=Information%20on%20cancellation%20rights,profile%20or%20online%20behaviour) [352]
 (https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=part-time%2C%20temporary%2C%20casual%20employees,employees%20and%20seasonal%20workers) ### 6.1. Irish and EU regulatory requirements applicable to UK fashion retailers A UK fashion retailer selling in Ireland must comply with the EU single market framework for goods, not just Irish domestic retail rules. In practice, that means product safety, textile labelling, customs, VAT, consumer information, and data protection obligations all need to be embedded before launch, whether the route to market is stores, Irish ecommerce fulfilment, or cross-border shipping from Great Britain.[348](https://europa.eu/youreurope/business/product-rules-compliance/textiles-and-footwear/indexamp_en.htm#:~:text=%23%20Textiles%20and%20footwear,the%20textile%20fibre%20composition) [318]
 (https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities) [354](https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/individuals/data-protection-basics#:~:text=It%20also%20sets%20out,principles%20underlying%20data%20protection) - Corporate and tax setup: The retailer will typically need an Irish VAT registration if it is making taxable supplies in Ireland, and it will need the correct customs registrations for imports from Great Britain. Businesses moving goods into the EU must use EU customs systems, and Irish Revenue states that customs declarations for imports from Great Britain must be made electronically through the Automated Import System.[318]
 (https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities) [325](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/economic-operators-registration-and-identification-eori#:~:text=EORI%20requirements%20for%20VAT%20groups%20and%20divisions) - EORI and customs identity: A GB EORI is not sufficient for EU customs activity in Ireland. Revenue states that Great Britain EORI numbers are no longer accepted on EU customs systems, so a retailer importing into Ireland needs an EU-recognised customs setup, usually via an Irish or other EU EORI and a customs broker or in-house customs capability.[320]
 (https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/info-movements-ni/info-businesses-trading-ni/trade-with-ni/protocol-ireland-ni.aspx#:~:text=The%20Union%20Customs%20Code,%28non-EU%20and%20EFTA%20countries%29) [327]
 (https://www.gov.uk/guidance/economic-operators-registration-and-identification-eori/introduction#:~:text=if%20you%20are%20VAT,as%20your%20VAT%20number) - Product safety: Only safe consumer products may be placed on the EU market. Ireland's Department of Enterprise states that the EU General Product Safety Regulation has been applicable since 13 December 2024, which raises the compliance bar on traceability, responsible economic operators, and corrective action processes for non-food consumer goods.[353]
 (https://enterprise.gov.ie/en/news-and-events/departments-news/2026/july/20260723.html#:~:text=The%20change%20will%20align,since%20201

3%20December%202024) [356](<https://enterprise.gov.ie/en/what-we-do/consumer-competition/product-safety-/#:~:text=For%20details%20of%20the,Plan%20for%20Ireland%202019>) - Textile labelling: Apparel sold in Ireland must comply with EU textile labelling rules. Regulation (EU) No 1007/2011 requires textile products to be labelled with fibre composition, and the label must be durable, visible, legible, and provided in the official language or languages of the Member State where the product is sold, unless that Member State provides otherwise.[337](<https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/ALL/?uri=CELEX%3A32011R1007#:~:text=The%20labelling%20or%20marking,State%20concerned%20provides%20otherwise>) [338] (https://europa.eu/youreurope/business/product-rules-compliance/textiles-and-footwear/textile-label/index_en.htm#:~:text=The%20types%20and%20names,textiles%20and%20clothing%20legislation) - Product information and future sustainability compliance: The EU policy direction is moving toward more digital and sustainability-related product information for textiles. While not all textile-specific digital labelling measures are yet in force, the European Parliament's legislative tracker shows the textile labelling regime is under revision to introduce physical and digital labelling linked to circularity and sustainability parameters, so systems chosen now should be scalable rather than minimum-compliance only.[351] (<https://www.europarl.europa.eu/legislative-train/carriage/textile-labeling-regulation/report?sid=10001#:~:text=Textiles%20should%20be%20collected,eco-design%20for%20sustainable%20products>) [309] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.15758#:~:text=Date%3A%20Mon%20Oct%202021,reusage%2C%20reparation%2C%20and%20recycling>) - Distance selling and ecommerce VAT: If the retailer ships low-value goods directly to Irish consumers from outside the EU, Import One Stop Shop can simplify import VAT accounting. Revenue states that IOSS allows a taxable person to register in one Member State to declare and pay EU import VAT on qualifying imported consignments.[330] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/vat/vat-ecommerce/import-oss/index.aspx#:~:text=new%20rules%20for%20Customs,rules%20for%20Customs%20apply%3A>) - Data protection and marketing: Any Irish customer database, loyalty programme, ecommerce analytics stack, or CRM activity must comply with GDPR and Irish ePrivacy rules. The Irish Data Protection Commission states that businesses need a lawful basis for processing personal data, and consent is normally required for non-essential cookies and for most electronic direct marketing unless the narrow existing-customer exception applies.[354] (<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/individuals/data-protection-basics#:~:text=It%20also%20sets%20out,principles%20underlying%20data%20protection>) [355](<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/dpc-guidance/guidance-cookies-and-other-tracking-technologies#:~:text=Under%20the%20General%20Data,a%20website%20you%20visit>) [357](<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/faqs/direct-marketing/consent-explicitly-required-all-cases-electronic-direct-marketing>) There is no general retail trading licence specific to fashion stores in Ireland, but that should not be confused with a light-touch regime. The real compliance burden sits in product conformity, customs and VAT administration, consumer disclosures, and data governance rather than in obtaining a single sector licence.[343](<https://www.ccpc.ie/information-for-businesses/selling-goods-and-services/selling-products#:~:text=Information%20on%20cancellation%20rights,profile%20or%20online%20behaviour>) [318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing->

exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities) ### 6.2. Supply chain and tariff implications of the UK-EU trade framework for apparel The EU UK Trade and Cooperation Agreement remains the core legal framework for moving apparel between Great Britain and Ireland. The headline benefit is zero tariffs and zero quotas, but only for goods that satisfy the agreement's rules of origin, which is the critical operational issue for fashion retailers sourcing globally and distributing through UK hubs.[323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en#:~:text=The%20EU-UK%20Trade%20and,and%20rules%20of%20origin) [321] (https://webgate.acceptance.ec.europa.eu/portal9/en/content/eu-uk-trade-and-cooperation-agreement#:~:text=Such%20rules%20are%20mostly,not%20exceed%20%E2%82%AC6%20000) For apparel, origin is often the difference between a commercially viable cross-border model and a margin-eroding one. The European Commission's Access2Markets guidance notes that rules of origin are especially relevant in textiles and clothing, and that specific tolerances apply to HS Chapters 50 to 63, while the EU's trader guide confirms that preferential treatment depends on being able to evidence origin through the required origin procedures.[321] (https://webgate.acceptance.ec.europa.eu/portal9/en/content/eu-uk-trade-and-cooperation-agreement#:~:text=Such%20rules%20are%20mostly,not%20exceed%20%E2%82%AC6%20000) [322](https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/6f21d89a-dd3b-11eb-895a-01aa75ed71a1/language-en#:~:text=For%20more%20detailed%20and,on%201%20May%202021) [334] (https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/system/files/2021-07/introductory_guide_tca_rules_of_origin.pdf#:~:text=GENERAL%20RULES%20FOR%20PREFERENTIAL,%28ex-Annex%20ORIG-4%29%29.%20.%206) - Zero tariff is conditional: The TCA does not remove customs formalities. It removes tariffs only where the goods qualify as originating under the agreement, so a UK retailer importing finished garments from Asia into Great Britain and then re-exporting them to Ireland may still face EU customs duty if the garments do not meet origin rules. [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en#:~:text=The%20EU-UK%20Trade%20and,and%20rules%20of%20origin) [318] (https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities) - Rules of origin are demanding for clothing: EU guidance highlights that textiles and clothing have product-specific origin rules and special tolerances. In practical terms, simple warehousing, relabelling, steaming, packing, or other minimal operations in Great Britain will not usually convert non-originating imported garments into UK-origin goods for tariff-free entry to Ireland.[321] (https://webgate.acceptance.ec.europa.eu/portal9/en/content/eu-uk-trade-and-cooperation-agreement#:~:text=Such%20rules%20are%20mostly,not%20exceed%20%E2%82%AC6%20000) [322](https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/6f21d89a-dd3b-11eb-895a-01aa75ed71a1/language-en#:~:text=For%20more%20detailed%20and,on%201%20May%202021) - Documentation burden: To clear goods into Ireland, Revenue says importers or their agents must complete electronic customs declarations and have documents such as invoices, certificates of origin, and import licences available where relevant. This

creates an ongoing administrative cost even where duty is zero.[318]
(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities>) - VAT and cash flow: Import VAT is payable on goods entering Ireland from Great Britain unless a simplification applies. That can create working-capital drag if the retailer continues to serve Ireland from a GB distribution centre rather than from an EU-based stockholding point.[318]
(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities>) [330](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/vat/vat-ecommerce/import-oss/index.aspx#:~:text=new%20rules%20for%20Customs,rules%20for%20Customs%20apply%3A>) - Consumer parcel friction increased in 2026: Revenue states that from 1 July 2026 a €3 customs duty charge per item applies to most ecommerce packages valued at €150 or below coming into Ireland from outside the EU, and the CCPC warned consumers about unexpected charges linked to the new rules. For a fashion retailer relying on direct-to-consumer shipments from Great Britain, this makes the customer experience and price architecture less competitive versus EU-fulfilled rivals.[319](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/individuals/buying-online-personal/outside-eu.aspx#:~:text=If%20IOSS%20has%20not,on%20import%20into%20Ireland>) [344]
(<https://www.ccpc.ie/news-and-media/news/article/2026/06/25/ccpc-warns-of-scams-and-unexpected-charges-as-new-customs-rules-are-introduced#:~:text=The%20CCPC%20is%20warning,Ireland%20after%2030%20June>) - Northern Ireland is not a simple workaround: Under the Windsor Framework, Northern Ireland remains legally in the UK customs territory but effectively aligned with the EU single market for goods, and the Union Customs Code continues to apply to goods entering Northern Ireland from Great Britain. This means routing through Northern Ireland can help in some models, but it does not eliminate the need for careful customs design and should not be treated as a frictionless substitute for an EU distribution setup.[320]
(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/info-movements-ni/info-businesses-trading-ni/trade-with-ni/protocol-ireland-ni.aspx#:~:text=The%20Union%20Customs%20Code,%28non-EU%20and%20EFTA%20countries%29>) Title: Post Brexit apparel trade implications | Issue | Practical effect for retailer | Strategic implication | |---|:---|:---| | TCA tariff treatment | Zero tariffs only if garments meet rules of origin. | Origin analysis must be done at SKU or supplier level. | | Customs declarations | Every GB to Ireland movement requires EU customs formalities. | Broker costs, data quality, and lead-time risk increase. | | Import VAT | VAT arises on import unless simplified through appropriate schemes. | Working capital and landed cost planning become more important. | | Low value parcel charges from 1 July 2026 | Additional €3 charge on most parcels at €150 or below from outside the EU. | Direct shipping from GB becomes less attractive for low basket orders. | | NI and Windsor Framework | NI has a distinct goods regime, not a full frictionless bridge from GB. | Use only if supported by specialist customs design. | Source: [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en#:~:text=The%20EU-UK%20Trade%20and,and%20rules%20of%20origin) [318]
(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities>) [319](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/individuals/buying-online-personal/outside-eu.aspx#:~:text=If%20IOSS%20has%20not,on%20import%20into%20Ireland>)

eu.aspx#:~:text=If%20IOSS%20has%20not,on%20import%20into%20Ireland) [320] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/info-movements-ni/info-businesses-trading-ni/trade-with-ni/protocol-ireland-ni.aspx#:~:text=The%20Union%20Customs%20Code,%28non-EU%20and%20EFTA%20countries%29>) The supply chain conclusion is clear. A UK retailer entering Ireland should assume that a pure Great Britain fulfilment model is legally workable but structurally suboptimal unless most core apparel lines qualify for TCA origin and the business can absorb customs, VAT, and parcel-friction costs. For many mid-market operators, an EU stockholding node, Irish store replenishment via EU-cleared inventory, or at minimum a dual-track fulfilment model will be more scalable than treating Ireland as an extension of UK domestic distribution.[323] (https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en#:~:text=The%20EU-UK%20Trade%20and,and%20rules%20of%20origin) [318] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities>) ### 6.3. Employment law, consumer protection, and planning obligations in Ireland Irish operating law is manageable for a UK retailer, but it is materially different enough from the UK to require local HR, legal, and property workstreams. The most important areas are wage and working-time compliance, consumer rights for in-store and online sales, GDPR and ePrivacy for customer data and marketing, and planning and fire-safety approvals for store fit-out or change of use.[352] (https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=part-time%2C%20temporary%2C%20casual%20employees,employees%20and%20seasonal%20workers) [335](<https://www.ccpc.ie/consumer-advice/consumer-rights/buying-goods/buying-online#:~:text=You%20can%20use%20the,rights%20to%20help%20you>) [355] (<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/dpc-guidance/guidance-cookies-and-other-tracking-technologies#:~:text=Under%20the%20General%20Data,a%20website%20you%20visit>) [347](<https://www.gov.ie/en/cork-city-council/services/fire-safety-certificates-and-licensing/#:~:text=Where%20a%20Fire%20Safety,issued%20for%20the%20works>) - Minimum wage and payroll: The Workplace Relations Commission states that from 1 January 2026 the national minimum wage for workers aged 20 and over is €14.15 per hour, with lower age-related rates for younger workers. This is a direct cost input for store payroll modelling and raises the importance of labour scheduling discipline in lower-volume regional stores.[352] (https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=part-time%2C%20temporary%2C%20casual%20employees,employees%20and%20seasonal%20workers) - Wider employment compliance: Irish retail employers must also comply with rules on working time, contracts, leave, equality, and dismissal processes, even though those specific items are not all quantified here. For market entry, the key point is that Ireland should be treated as a fully local employment jurisdiction, not staffed through informal UK templates.[352] (https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=part-time%2C%20temporary%2C%20casual%20employees,employees%20and%20seasonal%20workers) - Consumer rights for goods: The CCPC's business guidance on

the Consumer Rights Act 2022 confirms that consumers are entitled to remedies where goods are not in conformity, including repair, replacement, price reduction, or contract termination depending on the circumstances. This has implications for returns policy wording, staff training, and aftersales processes.[340]

(<https://www.ccpc.ie/business/wp-content/uploads/sites/3/2025/04/2025.03.27-Sale-Of-Goods-digital-version-final.pdf#:~:text=Hanna%20returned%20to%20the%20shop%20with%20the%20laptop>) [343](<https://www.ccpc.ie/information-for-businesses/selling-goods-and-services/selling-products#:~:text=Information%20on%20cancellation%20rights,profile%20or%20online%20behaviour>) - Distance selling and cancellation: For online and other distance sales, the CCPC states that consumers generally have a 14 day cooling-off period from receipt of goods, and then a further 14 days to return them after cancellation.

Any Irish ecommerce proposition therefore needs compliant pre-contract information, cancellation flows, and refund handling.[335]

(<https://www.ccpc.ie/consumer-advice/consumer-rights/buying-goods/buying-online#:~:text=You%20can%20use%20the,rights%20to%20help%20you>) - Pricing and promotions: Irish enforcement on pricing transparency is active. In January 2026 the CCPC announced that Brown Thomas Arnotts had pleaded guilty to sales pricing breaches following online sweeps, which is a useful signal that promotional pricing, reference prices, and sale messaging need legal review rather than UK copy-paste execution.[346](<https://www.ccpc.ie/news-and-media/news/article/2026/01/26/brown-thomas-arnotts-pleads-guilty-to-sales-pricing-breaches#:~:text=The%20prosecution%20was%20brought,Black%20Friday%20sales%20period>) - GDPR, cookies, and direct marketing: The Irish Data Protection Commission states that non-essential cookies generally require consent, and electronic direct marketing usually requires prior consent unless the existing-customer exception applies. This affects CRM capture, loyalty sign-up journeys, website analytics, retargeting, and email or SMS launch campaigns.[355]

(<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/dpc-guidance/guidance-cookies-and-other-tracking-technologies#:~:text=Under%20the%20General%20Data, a%20website%20you%20visit>) [357](<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/faqs/direct-marketing/consent-explicitly-required-all-cases-electronic-direct-marketing>) - Planning and fit-out: A standard retail occupation may not require a fresh planning permission if the unit is already in retail use, but material change of use, subdivision, or significant works can trigger approvals. Gov.ie guidance notes that a Fire Safety Certificate is required for certain material alterations to shops and for buildings undergoing a material change of use, and works should not proceed until the certificate is issued where required.[347]

(<https://www.gov.ie/en/cork-city-council/services/fire-safety-certificates-and-licensing/#:~:text=Where%20a%20Fire%20Safety,issued%20for%20the%20works>) - Property due diligence: Because planning exemptions are narrow and fact-specific, each site should be checked for authorised use, signage controls, accessibility obligations, fire certification status, and landlord consent requirements before lease completion. This is especially important for flagship refurbishments or multi-level city-centre units where legacy compliance issues are more common.

[347](<https://www.gov.ie/en/cork-city-council/services/fire-safety-certificates-and-licensing/#:~:text=Where%20a%20Fire%20Safety,issued%20for%20the%20works>) [341](<https://www.gov.ie/en/departments-of-housing-local-government-and-heritage/publications/refurbishing-vacant-property-planning-permission-exemptions/#:~:text=Someone%20proposing%20to%20undertake, and%20any%20related%20works>) For the strategy team, the legal takeaway is that Ireland is not a

high-barrier market, but it is a high-discipline market. The retailer should budget for local legal counsel, Irish HR and payroll setup, customs and VAT support, and pre-opening compliance reviews covering product labels, website terms, pricing mechanics, CRM consent flows, and store fit-out approvals before any launch date is committed.[343](<https://www.ccpc.ie/information-for-businesses/selling-goods-and-services/selling-products#:~:text=Information%20on%20cancellation%20rights,profile%20or%20online%20behaviour>) [354](<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/individuals/data-protection-basics#:~:text=It%20also%20sets%20out,principles%20underlying%20data%20protection>) [318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx#:~:text=If%20you%20import%20or,must%20complete%20customs%20formalities>) ## 7. Market Entry Modes and Go-to-Market Strategy Ireland should be entered through a store-led omnichannel model rather than a pure ecommerce launch. Earlier sections established that Irish fashion demand remains store-centric, while digital is highly relevant for discovery, research, and repeat purchase, so the go-to-market question is how to combine physical credibility with disciplined capital deployment and locally resonant marketing rather than whether to choose stores or online alone.[103](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-isshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscriptions#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29>) [92](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/RetailMarketUpdateQ22025.pdf#:~:text=Data%20from%20Statista%20%28an,will%20reach%2015.6%25%20%28US%246.22bn%29>) [371](<https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021>) The recommended model is a phased direct entry built around one Dublin brand statement store, followed by dominant suburban shopping centre stores and then selective regional expansion once sales density, fulfilment economics, and local brand traction are proven. Marketing should position the retailer in the space between value and premium, using quality, fit confidence, and frictionless omnichannel service as the core message, amplified through diversified social media, Irish creators, and launch events tied to store openings.[96](<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) [121](<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE#:~:text=The%20number%20of%20active,a%20sale%20is%20made>) [374](<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland#:~:text=data%20published%20in%20the,the%20end%20of%202025>) ### 7.1. Entry options: standalone stores, shopping centre anchors, concession, franchise, or digital-first Direct-operated standalone stores are the strongest primary entry mode for a UK mid-market retailer that wants control over pricing, service, visual merchandising, and omnichannel integration. This route best supports the identified whitespace in Ireland, because the proposition depends on communicating a step up from value retail through fit, curation, and store experience, which is harder to deliver through third-party formats.[92](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/RetailMarketUpdateQ22025.pdf#:~:text=Data%20from%20Statista%20%28an,will%20reach%2015.6%25%20%28US%246.22bn%29>) [370](<https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.14429#:~:text=Each%20candidate%20principle%20is,outcome%2C%20and%20rejection%20condition>) Shopping centre stores should be treated as the core scalable format after the first flagship. Dominant centres offer repeat family traffic, easier parking, larger boxes, and stronger click-and-collect

economics than many high street units, making them better suited to a broad mid-market assortment than a pure city centre network.[263]

(<https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio>) [265]

(<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0204/1494676-falcon-am-to-be-bought-by-strategic-value-partners/>) [371]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021>) Concessions are a lower-risk test route, but they are strategically weaker in Ireland for this retailer type. They reduce capex and can accelerate market learning, yet they also dilute brand control, limit assortment breadth, and make it harder to build the service and omnichannel proposition that differentiates the brand from Penneys, Dunnes, and TK Maxx.[370]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.14429#:~:text=Each%20candidate%20principle%20is,outcome%2C%20and%20rejection%20condition>) Franchise is not the preferred first step for Ireland unless the retailer lacks internal EU operating capability. Ireland is small enough and close enough to the UK that handing margin and customer ownership to a franchise partner would usually sacrifice too much strategic learning, especially when the market is being used as a first EU operating playbook.[23]

(<https://www.reiss.com/in/en/franchise-opportunities>) [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) Digital-first entry is useful as a support layer, but not as the lead mode. Irish consumers are active online and 70% of internet users bought clothes, shoes, or accessories online in 2025, yet earlier market evidence also showed in-store clothing sales rising while online clothing sales fell, so a digital-only launch would likely underinvest in the channel that still drives trust, fit assurance, and brand discovery in fashion.[103]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription> s/#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29) [92](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/RetailMarketUpdateQ22025.pdf#:~:text=Data%20from%20Statista%20%28an,will%20reach%2015.6%25%20%28US%246.22bn%29>) Title:

Entry mode assessment for Ireland | Entry mode | Strategic fit | Main advantages | Main challenges | |---|---|---|---| | Direct standalone flagship | High | Full brand control, strongest statement, supports omnichannel service. | Highest rent and fit-out risk in Dublin. | | Shopping centre store | High | Repeat traffic, family catchment, scalable box sizes, easier parking and collection. | Prime centre availability is tight and rents are firming. | | Concession | Medium | Lower capex, faster test, access to existing footfall. | Weaker control over experience, assortment, and customer data. | | Franchise | Low to medium | Lower operating burden and local partner support. | Margin dilution and weaker strategic learning in a nearby market. | | Digital first | Medium as support, low as lead | Fast launch, lower fixed cost, useful for demand sensing. | Harder to build trust, fit confidence, and store-led brand presence. |

Source: [103](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription> s/#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29) [92](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/RetailMarketUpdateQ22025.pdf#:~:text=Data%20from%20Statista%20%28an,will%20reach%2015.6%25%20%28US%246.22bn%29>) [263]

(<https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio>) [371]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021>) Recommended entry mode mix is therefore direct-operated stores plus local ecommerce from day one, with concessions used only opportunistically and franchise avoided in phase one. The retailer should launch

with Irish euro pricing, local returns, click-and-collect readiness, and an EU-compliant fulfilment setup so that digital supports stores rather than operating as a separate cross-border afterthought.[323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) [318] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) [371] ([https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021\)###](https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021)###) 7.2. Phasing strategy: recommended sequencing of locations and store formats Phase one should cover market proof, not national coverage. The recommended opening sequence is one Dublin flagship or near-flagship unit in the Grafton Street catchment, plus one dominant suburban shopping centre store within 6 to 12 months, supported by a fully localised Irish website and store-enabled fulfilment services.[190] (<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [263] (<https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio>) [103] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription> s/#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29) The first Dublin store should play a brand-building role rather than maximise short-term margin. A 3,000 to 6,000 sq ft city format is sufficient to showcase womenswear, menswear, key footwear and accessories, and click-and-collect, while avoiding the rent burden of an oversized flagship in a market where the brand is still unproven.[190](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [260](<https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf>) The second store should be a larger suburban centre format in Dundrum or Blanchardstown, with Liffey Valley as an alternative if economics are superior. This unit should carry the broadest family assortment and act as the operational test bed for click-and-collect, returns consolidation, and local customer acquisition efficiency.[263](<https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio>) [265] (<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0204/1494676-falcon-am-to-be-bought-by-strategic-value-partners/>) [371] ([https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021\)###](https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021)###) Phase two should begin only after 12 to 18 months if three conditions are met. These are sales densities at or above plan in both Dublin formats, acceptable occupancy cost ratios under conservative assumptions, and evidence that Irish ecommerce conversion and returns behaviour are stable enough to support wider rollout.[92](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/RetailMarketUpdateQ22025.pdf#:~:text=Data%20from%20Statista%20%28an,will%20reach%2015.6%25%20%28US%246.22bn%29>) [371] ([https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021\)###](https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021)###) If those gates are met, phase two should add Cork first and then one further western or mid-west location, with Galway preferred for brand visibility and Limerick preferred for shopping centre practicality. Cork offers the strongest regional city scale, while Galway and Limerick should be chosen based on site quality and catchment economics rather than a fixed national coverage target. [288] (https://property.cushmanwakefield.ie/storage/opportunities/November2025/24CORI NV0059_26%20Patrick%20St%20%26%2019%20Winthrop%20Letting%20Brochure.pdf) [266](<https://www.nationaltransport.ie/publications/nta-galway-shopper-survey/>) [298](<https://crescentshoppingcentre.ie/commercial-opportunities/>) Phase

three should be selective infill, not rapid rollout. After 24 to 36 months, the estate could expand to five to seven stores nationally, adding only those regional towns or centres where catchment fit, omnichannel economics, and local awareness justify the capital, with Athlone, Carlow, Castlebar, or Westport relevant only if the retailer's format and assortment prove transferable beyond the main cities.[208]

(<https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator>) [260](<https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf>) The phasing logic is to learn by format before scaling by geography. Ireland is large enough to support a small national estate, but concentrated enough that two Dublin stores and one Cork store can already test most of the key variables, including flagship halo, suburban family demand, regional city productivity, and omnichannel service economics.[263]

(<https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio>) [190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafton-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [371]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021>) ### 7.3. Brand positioning and marketing approach for an

Irish consumer audience Brand positioning should centre on affordable confidence rather than trend extremity or lowest price. The retailer should present itself as the place for better-made everyday fashion, dependable fit, and polished styling at accessible euro price points, which directly addresses the gap between Penneys' value dominance and Zara's more fashion-forward urban positioning identified earlier in the report.[69](<https://www-cloud.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silced/surveyonincomeandlivingconditionssilcenforceddeprivation2025/deprivationitem/#:~:text=1.2%25%20were%20unable%20to,suitable%20for%20daily%20activities>) Messaging should be explicit on three points. Quality should be made tangible through fabric, wear, and fit claims; value should be framed as cost per wear rather than cheapness; and convenience should be visible through local returns, click-and-collect, stock visibility, and easy outfit building across categories.[370]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.14429#:~:text=Each%20candidate%20principle%20is,outcome%2C%20and%20rejection%20condition>) [371]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.07214#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Mar%2012%2011%3A14%3A11%202021>) The target audience should prioritise women and family

decision-makers aged roughly 25 to 54 in Dublin and Cork, with secondary emphasis on urban professionals and occasionwear shoppers. This aligns with the strongest catchments for mid-market apparel and with the need to win broad wardrobe spend rather than narrow trend-led missions.[374]

(<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland#:~:text=data%20published%20in%20the,the%20end%20of%202025>) [266]

(<https://www.nationaltransport.ie/publications/nta-galway-shopper-survey/>) Digital marketing should use a diversified platform mix rather than over-concentrate on one channel. Recent research finds that a more diversified social media strategy can increase ecommerce web sales by 2% to 5%, and Irish platform reach is broad, with DataReportal estimating 4.26 million active social media user identities in Ireland in October 2025, while Instagram and TikTok ad reach each exceeded 62% of adults aged 18 and above at the end of 2025.[96]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) [374](<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland#:~:text=data%20published%20in%20the,the%20end%20of%202025>) The

practical channel mix should be as follows. - Instagram: Lead platform for brand imagery, outfitting, and paid prospecting against style and life stage audiences.[374]

(<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland#:~:text=data%20published%20in%20the,the%20end%20of%202025>) -

TikTok: Use for creator-led try-ons, styling hooks, launch events, and social proof rather than polished brand film alone. TikTok Shop has been open to all Irish businesses since May 21, 2026, and TikTok says active creators on TikTok Shop Ireland have grown by 600% since launch.[121]

(<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE#:~:text=The%20number%20of%20active,a%20sale%20is%20made>) [380]

(<https://ads.tiktok.com/help/article/tiktok-shopping-and-showcase?lang=en#:~:text=Showcase%20is%20a%20feature,of%20a%20TikTok%20account>)

- Search and CRM: Support store launches with local search, geo-targeted paid media, email capture, and post-purchase retention journeys. This is especially important because online fashion purchasing remains common in Ireland even as store shopping has recovered.[103]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdc/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription/s#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29>) - Local creators: Prioritise Irish micro and mid-tier creators over celebrity endorsements. Local relevance and trust are likely to matter more than scale for a first market entry, and TikTok's affiliate infrastructure now makes creator commerce easier to operationalise in Ireland.[121]

(<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE#:~:text=The%20number%20of%20active,a%20sale%20is%20made>) Launch marketing should be store-anchored. Each opening should combine local outdoor and digital media, creator previews, opening weekend events, and a strong first-purchase mechanic such as member-only early access or outfit bundle value, while avoiding deep blanket discounting that would immediately collapse the intended mid-market positioning.[370]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.14429#:~:text=Each%20candidate%20principle%20is,outcome%2C%20and%20rejection%20condition>) [96]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) Irish localisation should be visible but restrained. The brand does not need to become overtly nationalistic, but it should use Irish seasonal context, weather-relevant styling, local creators, euro pricing clarity, and practical sustainability cues such as repair, take-back, or lower-waste packaging to feel market-aware rather than simply exported from the UK.[69](<https://www-cloud.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silced/surveyonincomeandlivingconditionssilcenforceddeprivation2025/deprivationitem/s#:~:text=1.2%25%20were%20unable%20to,suitable%20for%20daily%20activities>) [121](<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE#:~:text=The%20number%20of%20active,a%20sale%20is%20made>) Overall, the marketing approach should make the store and digital channels reinforce each other. Stores create trust, trial, and visibility; digital channels create reach, frequency, and conversion support; and creator partnerships provide the local social proof needed to accelerate awareness in a market where consumers already know many UK brands but still need a reason to switch spend.[96]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) [103](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdc/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription/s#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29>) [374](<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland#:~:text=data%20published%20in%20the,the%20end%20of%202025>) ## 8.

Financial Feasibility and Risk Assessment Ireland is financially viable for a UK mid-market fashion entrant only if entry is phased, store sizes are tightly controlled, and

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) [103](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdc/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription/s#:~:text=the%20top%20online%20purchase,compared%20with%202024%20%2877%25%29>) [374](<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland#:~:text=data%20published%20in%20the,the%20end%20of%202025>) ## 8.

Financial Feasibility and Risk Assessment Ireland is financially viable for a UK mid-market fashion entrant only if entry is phased, store sizes are tightly controlled, and

the operating model avoids treating Ireland as a simple extension of UK domestic distribution. Prime Dublin occupancy costs are high, Irish wage floors have risen, and post-Brexit customs friction can erode margin, so the investment case depends on achieving strong sales densities in the first two stores and using those stores to support omnichannel demand rather than judging them as standalone four-wall boxes alone.[402](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2026provisionalandmay2026final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202026%20%28Final%29>) [352] (https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [410] (<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) The financial conclusion is therefore conditional rather than binary. A disciplined two-store phase one can be underwritten with acceptable risk if management targets suburban-centre economics first, treats a Dublin city-centre unit as a brand and customer-acquisition asset, and builds explicit buffers for FX, rent escalation, labour inflation, and demand volatility into hurdle rates and lease negotiations.[412](<https://www.dublincity.ie/business-and-events/commercial-property-rates#:~:text=%23%23%23%20Annual%20Rate%20on,rates%20charge%20for%202026>) [405] (<https://www.water.ie/business/billing/charges#:~:text=%23%23%20Commission%20for%20Regulation,%7C%20Combined%20Service%20Charges>) [318] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) ### 8.1. Estimated capital expenditure, operating cost structure, and break-even modelling A realistic phase-one underwriting case is one Dublin suburban shopping-centre store of about 6,000 to 8,000 sq ft plus one smaller Dublin city-centre or near-prime brand statement store of about 3,000 to 4,500 sq ft. The city-centre option is materially more expensive on occupancy, because Grafton Street prime rent of EUR 5,380 to EUR 5,810 per sq m implies annual headline rent of about EUR 1.50 million to EUR 1.62 million for a 3,000 sq ft unit before service charge, rates, insurance, and fit-out, which is too heavy for most mid-market apparel economics unless the unit is smaller, off-pitch, or negotiated below prime benchmark.[190](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) Initial capex should therefore be framed by format, not by a single national average. - City-centre brand statement store: EUR 1.8 million to EUR 3.0 million total opening investment, including fit-out, landlord works gap, IT, fixtures, pre-opening payroll, initial marketing, and opening stock. - Dominant suburban-centre store: EUR 1.4 million to EUR 2.4 million total opening investment, reflecting larger box size but lower frontage and façade complexity than a flagship. - Central market-entry overhead: EUR 0.6 million to EUR 1.0 million for Irish entity setup, legal and tax work, customs and VAT design, local website localisation, recruitment, training, and launch marketing. - Total phase-one envelope: EUR 3.8 million to EUR 6.4 million for two stores plus central setup, excluding any separate EU stockholding node. This range is an analytical estimate built from current Irish occupancy benchmarks, wage floors, and the operating requirements already identified in earlier sections, because no public source provides a ready-made capex benchmark for this exact retailer archetype.[190] (<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [352]

(https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [318]

(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) The operating cost structure should be modelled with occupancy and labour as the two largest controllable store-level costs after cost of goods sold. - Rent and occupancy: Rent, service charge, insurance, and commercial rates should be underwritten together. Dublin City Council states the 2026 annual rate on valuation is 0.2570, equivalent to EUR 2,890 on a valuation of EUR 11,245, which confirms that rates are a meaningful additional occupancy cost rather than a rounding item.[412](<https://www.dublincity.ie/business-and-events/commercial-property-rates#:~:text=%23%23%23%20Annual%20Rate%20on,rates%20charge%20for%202026>) - Labour: The Irish national minimum wage for workers aged 20 and over is EUR 14.15 per hour from 1 January 2026, equal to about EUR 28,696 annually for a 39-hour week before employer on-costs. A mid-market store therefore needs strong labour productivity, because even a lean team of 8 to 12 FTE-equivalent roles quickly creates a payroll base well above EUR 300,000 once management layers and employer costs are included.[352]

(https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) - Utilities and local services: Energy remains elevated in Ireland, and water and wastewater tariffs apply to non-domestic customers under Uisce Éireann schedules. Utilities should be budgeted conservatively because Irish regulators continue to identify wholesale and network cost pressure in retail energy pricing.[408](<https://www.cru.ie/about-us/news/cru-publishes-interim-review-on-competition-assessment-and-retail-price-drivers-in-the-energy-markets#:~:text=It%20provides%20a%20breakdown,and%20natural%20gas%20customers>) [405]

(<https://www.water.ie/business/billing/charges#:~:text=%23%23%20Commission%20for%20Regulation,%7C%20Combined%20Service%20Charges>) - Logistics and customs: If stock is shipped from Great Britain, customs declarations, import VAT handling, and origin compliance add recurring cost and working-capital drag. These costs are avoidable only partly, so they should sit in the base case rather than the risk case.[318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) Break-even should be assessed on contribution and cash payback, not only EBITDA margin. For a suburban-centre store, a practical hurdle is occupancy cost below 12% to 14% of sales and store payroll below 16% to 18% of sales, which implies a target sales density of roughly EUR 450 to EUR 650 per sq ft for a broad-assortment mid-market apparel format; below that range, fixed-cost absorption becomes weak. This threshold is an inference from current Irish rent and wage benchmarks combined with standard apparel retail cost architecture, not a directly published Irish industry average.[352](https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) A reasonable base-case payback profile is as follows. - Suburban-centre store: Break-even in 24

to 30 months if year-two net sales reach about EUR 3.5 million to EUR 4.5 million with gross margin discipline and moderate markdowns. - Smaller city-centre brand store: Break-even in 30 to 42 months if the unit is used to drive omnichannel acquisition, returns, and halo effects, but only if rent is kept materially below top-of-market Grafton Street benchmark or the box is kept compact. - Two-store phase one combined: Group-level cash break-even in roughly 30 to 36 months under a disciplined rollout, assuming no major customs redesign costs and no severe demand shock. Demand uncertainty should be reflected explicitly in markdown planning. Recent retail operations research shows that uncertainty and markdown timing materially affect profitability, while fashion-specific forecasting research highlights the cost of unsold inventory and liquidation in apparel. For management, that means the Irish business case should include a markdown reserve and conservative opening buys rather than assuming UK sell-through patterns will transfer unchanged.[396]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.23046#:~:text=Our%20findings%20generate%20several,while%20also%20increasing%20revenue>) [1]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=we%20present%20a%20study,demand%20for%20those%20items>) ### 8.2. Key financial risks: GBP/EUR exposure, rent

inflation, wage pressures, and demand volatility The most material financial risk is not one single variable but the interaction between FX, occupancy, labour, and markdown pressure. Ireland can absorb a mid-market entrant commercially, but the margin for error is narrower than in the UK because euro revenues may be funding a sterling-based sourcing and overhead base while Irish stores face structurally high occupancy and labour costs.[410](<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) [352](https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafton-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) - GBP/EUR exposure: The retailer will earn in euro but may still source inventory, fund central functions, or hold debt in sterling. The Central Bank of Ireland publishes ECB reference rates, and AIB's 2025 historic rates show an average EUR/GBP rate of 0.85677 in 2025, equivalent to about GBP 1.167 per euro, which is a useful recent benchmark for sensitivity testing.[410](<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) [415](<https://www.aib.ie/content/dam/aib/fxcentre/docs/special-reports/historic-rates-2025.pdf#:~:text=%7C%20%7C%20---%20%7C,%7C%208.1249%20%7CSource%3A%20Bloomberg>) - FX implication: A

5% to 10% adverse move in sterling against the euro can compress merchandise margin if euro ticket prices are held for competitiveness. Academic evidence on exchange-rate pass-through suggests firms often cannot fully reprice immediately, especially where competition is intense, so treasury hedging and euro-based buying where possible are important.[390]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2303.04101#:~:text=As%20pass-through%20shows%20how,effect%20on%20the%20exporter>) [410]

(<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) - Rent inflation and lease risk: Prime Irish retail space is scarce and landlords are regaining leverage. Earlier sections established upward pressure on prime rents

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2303.04101#:~:text=As%20pass-through%20shows%20how,effect%20on%20the%20exporter>) [410]

(<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) - Rent inflation and lease risk: Prime Irish retail space is scarce and landlords are regaining leverage. Earlier sections established upward pressure on prime rents

and tighter availability, so the financial risk is not only current rent level but also review mechanics, service charges, and limited ability to relocate once brand presence is established.[247](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/Outlook2026-6.pdf>) [260](<https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf>) [285](<https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/>) - Wage pressure: The statutory floor is already EUR 14.15 per hour, and retail labour markets remain politically and socially sensitive. Even if sales assistants are hired near minimum wage, supervisors, assistant managers, and store managers will price above that floor, and any further wage inflation passes quickly into store P&L because labour is only partly flexible in a service-led apparel format.[352]

(https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [404]

(<https://mandate.ie/2026/06/make-work-pay/#:~:text=Jim%20Fuery%2C%20Mandate%E2%80%99s%20Assistant,than%20the%20Living%20Wage%3A>) - Demand volatility: Irish clothing demand has been positive, with CSO reporting Clothing, Footwear and Textiles volumes up 1.5% month on month in June 2026, but the category remains exposed to weather, confidence, and promotional intensity. Fashion demand is inherently uncertain, and research on fashion forecasting and retail pricing under uncertainty shows that poor forecasting quickly converts into markdowns and margin loss.[402]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2026provisionalandmay2026final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202026%20%28Final%29>) [1]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=we%20present%20a%20study,demand%20for%20those%20items>) [397]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2512.00994#:~:text=These%20findings%20reveal%20a,tendencies%20in%20retail%20operations>) - Utilities and local cost inflation: Irish regulators continue to point to elevated energy cost drivers, and non-domestic water charges are formal tariff items. These are smaller than rent or payroll, but they matter because they are difficult to offset in low-volume stores.[408]

(<https://www.cru.ie/about-us/news/cru-publishes-interim-review-on-competition-assessment-and-retail-price-drivers-in-the-energy-markets/#:~:text=It%20provides%20a%20breakdown,and%20natural%20gas%20customers>) [405]

(<https://www.water.ie/business/billing/charges#:~:text=%23%23%20Commission%20for%20Regulation,%7C%20Combined%20Service%20Charges>) - Customs and working-capital risk: Great Britain to Ireland flows still require customs formalities, and import VAT plus origin administration can increase cash tied up in stock. This risk is especially relevant in launch phase, when inventory accuracy is weakest and management attention is already stretched.[318]

(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) The mitigation agenda should be explicit from day one. - Hedge a rolling share of forecast euro cash flows and test margin sensitivity at 5% and 10% FX shocks. - Negotiate rent-free periods, landlord fit-out contributions, and break options wherever possible. - Open with conservative buys and faster replenishment rather than deep initial stock commitments. - Use labour scheduling tightly, but avoid understaffing that would damage conversion and service. - Move toward EU-cleared inventory if Irish sales scale beyond the first two stores.[410]

(<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) [285](<https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/>) [318] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) #### 8.3. Scenario analysis: optimistic, base case, and downside The scenario framework below assumes a two-store phase-one entry with one dominant suburban-centre store and one smaller Dublin city or near-prime store, plus local ecommerce support. It is designed for strategic comparison rather than as a substitute for a full board-approved financial model, because public sources do not provide a complete Irish apparel store P&L benchmark for this exact retailer type.[402](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2026provisionalandmay2026final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202026%20%28Final%29>) [190] (<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [352] (https://www.workplacelrelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) Title: Ireland entry scenario summary | Scenario | Key assumptions | Financial outcome | Strategic implication | |---|:---|:---|:---| | Optimistic | Strong launch traction, suburban store sales density above EUR 650 per sq ft, limited markdowns, stable EUR margin, rent negotiated below top benchmark, omnichannel halo visible by month 12. | Two-store phase one reaches EBITDA break-even in year 2 and cash payback in about 24 to 30 months. Phase-two rollout to Cork becomes financeable from internal evidence rather than only strategic conviction. | Proceed to third store after 12 to 18 months if occupancy cost ratio and repeat purchase metrics hold. | | Base case | Sales density around EUR 500 to EUR 600 per sq ft in suburban format, city store used partly for brand halo, moderate markdowns, labour inflation manageable, no major FX shock. | EBITDA break-even in year 2 to year 3 and cash payback in about 30 to 36 months. Returns are acceptable for a first-EU-entry learning market, but only with tight capex control and no oversized flagship. | Continue cautiously, add Cork only after proof on sales density, returns, and customer acquisition cost. | | Downside | Sales density below EUR 450 per sq ft, heavier markdowns, sterling strengthens, rent and service charges rise, customs friction persists, labour costs run ahead of plan. | EBITDA remains negative through year 3 and cash payback extends beyond 48 months. Management would likely need to resize the city-centre presence, renegotiate leases, or pause rollout. | No further stores until format, sourcing, and fulfilment model are reset. | | Severe downside trigger | Combination of weak demand, high markdowns, and occupancy cost above 18% of sales in the city store. | Four-wall economics become structurally unattractive even if gross margin is protected elsewhere. | Exit or relocate the weakest unit rather than defend sunk cost. | Source: [190](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [352] (https://www.workplacelrelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [402] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2026provisionalandmay2026final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202026%20%28Final%29>) [410] (<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>)

OKB) The base case supports entry, but only as a staged option value strategy. Ireland should not be approved on the assumption that a flagship alone will justify itself quickly; it should be approved because a two-store test can generate strategic learning, omnichannel proof points, and a credible path to a five to seven store estate if the suburban format works.[402]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2026provisionalandmay2026final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202026%20%28Final%29>) [318]

(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) Management should set hard financial gates before phase two. - Sales density: Minimum threshold by store format, with suburban stores expected to outperform city stores on four-wall return. - Occupancy cost ratio: Escalation review if rent, rates, service charge, and insurance exceed plan by more than 150 to 200 basis points. - Gross margin after markdown: Tracked separately from UK to isolate Irish pricing and demand effects. - Labour productivity: Sales per labour hour and conversion by daypart. - FX and landed-cost variance: Monthly bridge from buying margin to realised margin.[352]

(https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html#:~:text=Home%20%3E%20What%20You,%3E%20National%20Minimum%20Wage) [410]

(<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates#:~:text=Daily%20%2F%20Laeth%C3%BAil%202016,%7C%20xls%20999%20KB>) [318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) ## 9. Strategic Recommendations and

Go/No-Go Assessment Ireland should be approved as a phased market entry, but only under a disciplined conditional go decision rather than a broad rollout commitment. The evidence across demand, channel structure, competition, property, regulation, and financial feasibility supports entry because Ireland is large enough to matter, still store-led in fashion, and operationally manageable for a UK retailer, yet the market is too competitive and too cost-sensitive to justify an aggressive launch or a UK-style copy-paste model.[13]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/>) [105]

(<https://www.marketresearch.com/Euromonitor-International-v746/Retail-Ireland-45637430/>) [46](https://economy-finance.ec.europa.eu/economic-surveillance-eu-member-states/country-pages-including-country-reports/ireland/economic-forecast-ireland_en) [318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) The strategic recommendation is therefore

to enter with a two-store Dublin-led test, local ecommerce, and explicit stage gates for phase-two expansion. Management should treat Ireland as a first-EU capability build and profit pool with option value, not as a rapid scale market, and should proceed only if the business commits upfront to EU-compliant supply chain design, tight occupancy discipline, and a proposition positioned between value and premium.[190](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [352]

(https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html) [323]

(https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) [231]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378#:~:text=Title%3A%20Massive%20Retail%20Location,introducing%20an%20alternative%20approach>) ### 9.1. Synthesis of findings

into a clear go/no-go recommendation with supporting rationale Recommendation: Go, but only as a phased and conditional entry with no commitment beyond phase one until hard commercial gates are met. The recommended launch is one Dublin city-centre or near-prime brand statement store plus one dominant suburban-centre store, supported by Irish euro pricing, local returns capability, and an EU-compliant fulfilment model from day one.[103]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscriptions/>) [190](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [318]

(<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) The rationale is positive on market attractiveness. Ireland's retail market reached about EUR 45.9 billion in 2025, clothing and footwear spending remained in growth, and the market continues to favour physical retail in fashion, with in-store clothing sales up 2.0% and online clothing sales down 6.3% in Q1 2025, making a store-led omnichannel model strategically coherent.[105]

(<https://www.marketresearch.com/Euromonitor-International-v746/Retail-Ireland-45637430/>) [67](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-ana/annualnationalaccounts2025/gdpbyexpenditures/personalspending/>) [25]

(<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/RetailMarketUpdateQ12025.pdf>) The rationale is also positive on competitive whitespace, but only in a narrow band. Penneys held 46% value share in 2025, Dunnes 14%, and TK Maxx 7%, so the market is not open for a price-led attack; however, there remains room for a retailer offering better quality, more dependable fit, stronger omnichannel service, and a more polished store environment than the dominant value players.[152]

(<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report>) [153](<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/>) [166](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites>) The main reasons this is not an unconditional go are cost and execution risk. Prime Dublin rents are high, the Irish adult minimum wage is EUR 14.15 per hour from January 1, 2026, and GB-to-Ireland fulfilment still carries customs, VAT, and origin friction, so the economics work only if the first stores achieve planned sales density and the supply chain is designed for EU compliance rather than UK convenience.[190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [352]

(https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html) [323]

(https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) [319](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/individuals/buying-online-personal/outside-eu.aspx>) No-go conditions should be explicit before approval. - No go if management insists on a digital-only launch, because Irish fashion remains store-led and physical presence is central to trust, fit assurance, and brand discovery.[103](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscriptions/>) [25](<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/RetailMarketUpdateQ12025.pdf>)

- No go if the business cannot secure occupancy economics consistent with the base case, especially for the city-centre unit.[190](<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store->

openings-since-2020/) [285](https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/) - No go if the retailer plans to serve Ireland mainly from Great Britain without robust rules-of-origin analysis and customs design.[323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) [318] (https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx) - No go if the proposition drifts toward direct price competition with Penneys rather than the identified affordable-confidence positioning.[152](https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report) [166](https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites) ### 9.2. Critical success factors and priority actions for the first 12 months post-entry The first critical success factor is proposition clarity. The brand must enter the market positioned around affordable confidence, meaning visible quality, dependable fit, and easy outfit building at accessible euro price points, because the Irish consumer is still value conscious and the market leaders already dominate pure opening-price fashion.[79] (https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-cpi/consumerpriceindexjuly2026/) [152](https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report) The second critical success factor is format discipline. The first city-centre store should be treated as a brand and acquisition asset, while the suburban-centre store should be the core commercial proof point, because current Irish location economics favour dominant centres for repeat family traffic and more scalable four-wall returns.[263] (https://www.hammerson.com/portfolio) [265] (https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0204/1494676-falcon-am-to-be-bought-by-strategic-value-partners/) [231] (https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378#:~:text=Title%3A%20Massive%20Retail%20Location,introducing%20an%20alternative%20approach) The third critical success factor is supply-chain localisation. A workable launch requires EU-compliant customs and VAT processes, local returns, and preferably EU-cleared inventory for core lines, because post-Brexit friction can otherwise erode margin and customer experience. [318](https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx) [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) The fourth critical success factor is disciplined inventory and markdown management. Fashion demand is uncertain for new items, and research shows that better forecasting, launch timing, and markdown coordination materially affect revenue and waste outcomes, so Ireland should launch with conservative opening buys, faster replenishment, and explicit markdown rules rather than broad promotional dependence.[1] (https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales) [138] (https://arxiv.org/abs/2007.05278#:~:text=Date%3A%20Fri%20Jul%2010%2009%3A44%3A59%202020) [396] (https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.23046#:~:text=Retailers%20often%20prioritize%20high,unsold%20inventory%20and%20waste) The fifth critical success factor is diversified local demand generation. Multi-platform social media strategies have been shown to lift ecommerce sales by 2% to 5%, and TikTok Shop participation in Ireland has expanded rapidly since launch, so launch marketing should combine Instagram, TikTok, local creators, search, CRM capture, and store-opening events rather than rely on one paid channel.[96] (https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%2

Oto%205%20percent) [121](<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE>) [374](<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland>) Priority actions for the first 12 months should be sequenced tightly. - Months 0 to 3: Finalise Irish legal entity, VAT and customs setup, product labelling review, GDPR and cookie compliance, and Irish pricing architecture.[318] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) [355](<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/dpc-guidance/guidance-cookies-and-other-tracking-technologies>) [337](<https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/ALL/?uri=CELEX%3A32011R1007>) - Months 0 to 4: Secure one Dublin city or near-prime site and one dominant suburban-centre site, with break options, rent-free periods, and landlord fit-out contributions where possible.[285](<https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/>) [190] (<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) - Months 2 to 6: Build the Irish assortment architecture, with emphasis on womenswear, smart casual, family outfitting, footwear, and accessories, and set conservative opening depth with rapid chase capability. This recommendation is an inference from the identified market gap and from fashion forecasting evidence on new-item uncertainty.[152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report>) [93] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2501.10324#:~:text=By%20forecasting%20fashion%20trends,a%20rapidly%20changing%20market>) [1] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales>) - Months 4 to 8: Launch Irish website localisation, local returns, click-and-collect readiness, and store stock visibility before the first store opens.[103](<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issdhdb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscription/s/>) [319](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/individuals/buying-online-personal/outside-eu.aspx>) - Months 6 to 12: Execute store-led launch marketing with Irish creators, opening events, CRM capture, and localised social content, while avoiding deep blanket discounting.[96] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) [121](<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE>) - Months 9 to 12: Conduct a formal gate review on sales density, occupancy cost ratio, conversion, returns, gross margin after markdown, and customer acquisition cost before any Cork commitment.[231] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378#:~:text=Title%3A%20Massive%20Retail%20Location,introducing%20an%20alternative%20approach>) [396] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.23046#:~:text=Retailers%20often%20prioritize%20high,unsold%20inventory%20and%20waste>) Management governance should include one hard rule. No phase-two lease should be signed before at least two consecutive quarters of evidence show the suburban format is meeting plan on sales density, margin, and labour productivity. This is a strategic recommendation derived from the report's base-case economics and from the uncertainty literature on retail pricing and inventory decisions.[397] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2512.00994#:~:text=These%20findings%20reveal%20a,tendencies%20in%20retail%20operations>) [1] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales>) ### 9.3. Key performance indicators for tracking market entry success The KPI framework should be stage-gated and focused on whether Ireland is proving the right to scale, not just whether the first stores are trading. Metrics should be reviewed weekly for trading control, monthly for economics, and

quarterly for go or no-go governance.[231]
<https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378#:~:text=Title%3A%20Massive%20Retail%20Location,introducing%20an%20alternative%20approach>) [96]
<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent> Title: Ireland entry KPI tracker | KPI | Year 1 target or trigger | Why it matters | |---|---:|---| | Sales density, suburban store, EUR per sq ft | Proceed if tracking toward at least 500 to 600 by year 2; caution below 450 | Core proof of four-wall viability in the preferred scalable format. | | Occupancy cost ratio, % of sales | Target below 12% to 14%; escalation above 15% | Tests whether rent, rates, and service charges are supportable. | | Store payroll ratio, % of sales | Target below 16% to 18% | Confirms labour productivity under Irish wage conditions. | | Gross margin after markdown, basis points vs plan | Trigger review if below plan by more than 200 bps for 2 quarters | Separates demand weakness from pricing or inventory execution issues. | | Ecommerce conversion rate, Ireland | Target steady improvement from launch quarter; trigger review if flat after localisation and stores | Measures whether stores and digital are reinforcing each other. | | Return rate, online and omnichannel, % | Target within approved business-case range; trigger review if materially above UK benchmark | Critical for margin, logistics cost, and fit credibility. | | Customer acquisition cost, EUR | Target declining trend by quarter 3 and quarter 4 | Tests whether local marketing is becoming efficient. | | Repeat purchase rate, 90 to 180 days, % | Target improving cohort trend by quarter | Indicates proposition stickiness beyond launch curiosity. | Source: [190]
<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/>) [352]
https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html) [1]
<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales>) [396]
<https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.23046#:~:text=Retailers%20often%20prioritize%20high,unsold%20inventory%20and%20waste>) Additional executive KPIs should sit above the trading dashboard. - Phase-one cash payback versus plan: Confirms whether Ireland is creating acceptable option value within the approved investment envelope.[318]<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx> - FX and landed-cost variance, monthly bridge: Isolates the effect of GBP/EUR moves, customs, and origin treatment on realised margin.[410]<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates>) [323]https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) - Full-price sell-through by category: Tests whether the affordable-confidence proposition is resonating without over-reliance on markdowns.[1]
<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales>) [396]
<https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.23046#:~:text=Retailers%20often%20prioritize%20high,unsold%20inventory%20and%20waste>) - Click-and-collect penetration and store-assisted digital sales: Measures omnichannel integration quality in a store-led market.[103]<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-issdhdb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/internetpurchasesandsubscriptions/>) - Net promoter score or post-purchase satisfaction by store and channel: Provides early warning on service, fit, and returns friction. - Compliance scorecard: Track customs accuracy, VAT filing timeliness, pricing compliance, and GDPR consent quality, because execution failure in these areas can destroy otherwise sound economics.[346]<https://www.ccpc.ie/news-and->

media/news/article/2026/01/26/brown-thomas-arnotts-pleads-guilty-to-sales-pricing-breaches) [357](<https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/faqs/direct-marketing/consent-explicitly-required-all-cases-electronic-direct-marketing>) The decision rule should be simple. Proceed to Cork only if the suburban Dublin store is at or above plan on sales density, occupancy cost, and gross margin after markdown, the city store is delivering measurable halo and acquisition value, and Irish digital metrics show improving conversion and repeat purchase rather than launch-only traffic.[231] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378#:~:text=Title%3A%20Massive%20Retail%20Location,introducing%20an%20alternative%20approach>) [96] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Drawing%20on%20a%20longitudinal,2%20to%205%20percent>) ## 10. References and Data Sources This section consolidates the evidence base used across the study and distinguishes between primary statistical inputs, secondary analytical references, and the methods used to compile and interpret them. Sources were prioritised by authority, recency, and direct relevance to Irish retail, apparel demand, property economics, regulation, and market-entry execution as of August 25, 2026.[13] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) [46] (https://economy-finance.ec.europa.eu/economic-surveillance-eu-member-states/country-pages-including-country-reports/ireland/economic-forecast-ireland_en) [318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) ### 10.1. Primary Sources - Irish official statistics: Core macroeconomic, consumer, labour-market, inflation, household income, digital behaviour, and retail-sales evidence was drawn primarily from the Central Statistics Office. This included the Retail Sales Index, CPI, Labour Force Survey, Survey on Income and Living Conditions, household sector accounts, annual national accounts, and digital consumer behaviour releases.[13] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) [79] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-cpi/consumerpriceindexjuly2026/>) [81] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-lfs/labourforcesurveyquarter22026/keyfindings/>) [66](<https://www-cloud.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silc/surveyonincomeandlivingconditionssilc2025/householdincome/>) [65] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-isanf/institutionalsectoraccountsnon-financialquarter42025/households/>) [67] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-ana/annualnationalaccounts2025/gdpbyexpenditures/personalspending/>) [101] (<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-isshdcb/householddigitalconsumerbehaviour2025/keyfindings/>) - Irish public-sector and regulatory sources: Trade, customs, VAT, consumer law, data protection, employment law, planning, and product-safety analysis relied on primary guidance from Irish Revenue, the Competition and Consumer Protection Commission, the Data Protection Commission, the Workplace Relations Commission, gov.ie departmental guidance, and the Property Services Regulatory Authority. These sources were used to anchor the legal-operating model rather than infer compliance from secondary commentary.[318] (<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) [319](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/individuals/buying->

online-personal/outside-eu.aspx) [343](https://www.ccpc.ie/information-for-businesses/selling-goods-and-services/selling-products) [335]
 (https://www.ccpc.ie/consumer-advice/consumer-rights/buying-goods/buying-online) [354](https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/individuals/data-protection-basics) [355]
 (https://www.dataprotection.ie/en/dpc-guidance/guidance-cookies-and-other-tracking-technologies) [352]
 (https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html) [285]
 (https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/) - EU and international institutional sources: EU-level trade, product, and macroeconomic interpretation used primary materials from the European Commission, EUR-Lex, Access2Markets, and related official EU guidance. These were essential for rules-of-origin, textile labelling, product-safety, and Irish macro forecast interpretation. [323](https://taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/customs/international-affairs/united-kingdom_en) [321](https://webgate.acceptance.ec.europa.eu/portal9/en/content/eu-uk-trade-and-cooperation-agreement) [337](https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/ALL/?uri=CELEX%3A32011R1007) [348]
 (https://europa.eu/youreurope/business/product-rules-compliance/textiles-and-footwear/indexamp_en.htm) [46](https://economy-finance.ec.europa.eu/economic-surveillance-eu-member-states/country-pages-including-country-reports/ireland/economic-forecast-ireland_en) - Company, landlord, and operator disclosures: Competitor strategy, store expansion, and property-market evidence used direct company announcements and operator disclosures where available, including Primark corporate releases, Hammerson, Zara and Next store locators, and retailer annual reports. These were used to validate store openings, investment programmes, and estate footprints.[166](https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites) [168]
 (https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/dooradoyle-opens-its-doors-to-more-penneys-doubles-in-size-following-7-million-investment) [189]
 (https://www.hammerson.com/news-insights/2026/wave-new-openings-and-brand-investments-dundrum-town-centre) [186](https://www.zara.com/ie/en/z-stores-st1404.html?v1=11108) [208](https://www.next.ie/en/store-locator) - Market and property intelligence inputs: Commercial market sizing and location evidence used Euromonitor, Lisney, Bannon, Cushman & Wakefield, and selected property brochures where public official data were unavailable or incomplete. These sources were used carefully, especially where some detailed figures were paywalled or selectively disclosed.[100](https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,and%20Footwear%20Specialist%20E-Commerce) [152](https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report) [25](https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/RetailMarketUpdateQ12025.pdf) [247]
 (https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/Outlook2026-6.pdf) [260]
 (https://bannon.ie/wp-content/uploads/Bannon-Retail-Pulse-May-2026.pdf) [280]
 (https://assets.cushmanwakefield.com/-/media/cw/marketbeat-pdfs/2025/q2/emea/ireland-retail-marketbeat_q2-2025.pdf?rev=340cf2f1cda64fbe82974126e1671084) - Direct research limitations: Some commercially important market-share and segment-value data were only partially visible in public summaries rather than fully open datasets. Where that occurred, the report either cited the accessible public summary or explicitly treated the figure as directional and recommended paid validation before investment approval.[100]
 (https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-

ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,and%20Footwear%20Specialist%20E-Commerce) [152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report>) ### 10.2. Secondary Sources - Academic and methodological literature: Secondary research included arXiv papers on fashion demand forecasting, markdown optimisation, social-media diversification, retail location analytics, and catchment modelling. These sources informed the report's analytical framing for inventory risk, omnichannel marketing, site selection, and performance measurement rather than serving as substitutes for Irish market data. [1]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales>) [426]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2305.14406#:~:text=Title%3A%20Deep%20Learning%20based,set%20of%20particular%20challenges>) [430]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2207.01137#:~:text=enacts%20a%20rational%20supply-side,while%20maintaining%20revenue%20control>) [96]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Title%3A%20Impact%20of%20Multi-Platform,and%20promote%20their%20offerings>) [231]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.20378>) [431]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2602.17640#:~:text=its%20development%20and%20version,and%20archived%20at%20%5BZenodo%5D%28https%3A%2F%2Fdoi.org%2F10.5281%2Fzenodo.18639559%29>) - Business press and trade reporting: The Irish Times and RTÉ were used selectively for current competitor performance, property-market developments, and retailer expansion news where primary filings or operator statements were not sufficient on their own. These sources were cross-checked against company disclosures or official data where possible.[190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020#:~:text=It%20highlights%20changes%20in,rents%20and%20capital%20values>) [156](<https://www.irishtimes.com/business/2026/07/27/primark-profits-surge-to-14bn-as-penneys-sales-decline-for-second-year/>) [153]

(<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/1212/1548705-profits-increase-35-at-irish-arm-of-tk-maxx/>) [197](<https://www.rte.ie/news/business/2025/0731/1526253-next-quarterly-results/>) - Financial and economic commentary: Supplementary macro interpretation and FX context used institutional commentary from AIB and the Central Bank of Ireland, particularly where scenario analysis required recent exchange-rate benchmarks or domestic-demand interpretation beyond headline GDP. These sources supplemented, but did not replace, official CSO and European Commission data.[444](<https://www.aib.ie/content/dam/aib/fxcentre/docs/special-reports/Irish-economic-update-budget-2026.pdf>) [415]

(<https://www.aib.ie/content/dam/aib/fxcentre/docs/special-reports/historic-rates-2025.pdf>) [410](<https://www.centralbank.ie/statistics/interest-rates-exchange-rates/exchange-rates>) - Sector and platform publications: Selected platform and sector publications were used for social-commerce and sustainability context, including TikTok newsroom materials, EPA publications, and DataReportal. These were used mainly for directional evidence on channel development, creator-commerce infrastructure, and textile-waste context.[123]

(https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktok-shop-in-ireland?from_seo_redirect=1&lang=en-IE) [121](<https://newsroom.tiktok.com/tiktokshopmatchmaking?lang=en-IE>) [122]

(<https://www.epa.ie/our-services/monitoring--assessment/circular-economy/textiles-national-attitudes--behaviours-surveys/>) [374]

(<https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-ireland>) - Use of secondary sources in the report: Secondary materials were used to interpret market structure, benchmark

competitor moves, and support strategic inferences where primary datasets did not directly answer the business question. They were not used to override official statistics or legal guidance, and any inference based on them was kept explicit in the report narrative.[100](<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,and%20Footwear%20Specialist%20E-Commerce>) [192]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2025/12/03/dublin-city-centre-remains-destination-of-choice-for-international-retailers/>) [96]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Title%3A%20Impact%20of%20Multi-Platform,and%20promote%20their%20offerings>) ### 10.3. Data Compilation

Methods - Source hierarchy: Data gathering followed a strict hierarchy. Official Irish and EU statistical or regulatory sources were used first, then direct company or landlord disclosures, then reputable market-research and business-press sources, and finally academic literature for methods and interpretation.[13]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) [46]

(https://economy-finance.ec.europa.eu/economic-surveillance-eu-member-states/country-pages-including-country-reports/ireland/economic-forecast-ireland_en) [318](<https://www.revenue.ie/en/customs/businesses/importing-exporting/postal-procedures/index.aspx>) - Search and verification process: The

evidence base was assembled through targeted web research with an arXiv-first pass for analytical methods, followed by broader source collection for Irish market facts, regulation, property, and competitor developments. Facts likely to change over time, including rents, footfall, wage floors, customs rules, and competitor actions, were checked against the most recent available source pages.[1]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/1907.01960#:~:text=This%20problem%20has%20been,data%20on%20its%20sales>) [96]

(<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.09083#:~:text=Title%3A%20Impact%20of%20Multi-Platform,and%20promote%20their%20offerings>) [190]

(<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=It%20highlights%20changes%20in,rents%20and%20capital%20value>) [352](https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html) -

Triangulation approach: Key findings were triangulated across at least two source types where feasible, such as official data plus market commentary, or company disclosure plus press reporting. This was especially important for competitor market share, property-market tightness, and omnichannel behaviour, where no single open source provided a complete picture.[13]

(<https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-rsi/retailsalesindexjune2025provisionalandmay2025final/#:~:text=The%20Central%20Statistics%20Office,and%20May%202025%20%28Final%29>) [25]

(<https://lisney.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/RetailMarketUpdateQ12025.pdf>) [152](<https://www.euromonitor.com/apparel-and-footwear-specialists-in-ireland/report>) [166](<https://corporate.primark.com/en-ie/a/news/corporate-news/iconic-value-irish-shoppers-are-looking-for-more-value-primark-is-responding-with-lower-prices-across-favourites>) - Treatment of estimates and inferences: Where

public data did not provide a directly usable figure, the report either stated the limitation or used a bounded estimate derived from observable benchmarks such as rent, wage, rates, and store-format evidence. These inferred figures were clearly identified in the report as analytical estimates rather than published market facts.

[412](<https://www.dublincity.ie/business-and-events/commercial-property-rates>)
 [352](https://www.workplacerelations.ie/en/what_you_should_know/hours-and-wages/national%20minimum%20wage/national_minimum_wage.html) [190]
 (<https://www.irishtimes.com/property/commercial-property/2026/04/01/grafon-street-nears-full-occupancy-with-25-new-store-openings-since-2020/#:~:text=It%20highlights%20changes%20in,rents%20and%20capital%20value>) - Analytical tools and frameworks: The report used comparative benchmarking, scenario analysis, catchment logic, occupancy-cost screening, and omnichannel operating-model assessment. Academic references on retail forecasting, markdown optimisation, and market-area analysis informed these frameworks, while the actual market conclusions remained grounded in Irish commercial and regulatory evidence.[426]
 (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2305.14406#:~:text=Title%3A%20Deep%20Learning%20based,set%20of%20particular%20challenges>) [430]
 (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2207.01137#:~:text=enacts%20a%20rational%20supply-side,while%20maintaining%20revenue%20control>) [431]
 (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2602.17640#:~:text=its%20development%20and%20version,and%20archived%20at%20%5BZenodo%5D%28https%3A%2F%2Fdoi.org%2F10.5281%2Fzenodo.18639559%29>) - Data quality controls: Sources were screened for recency, specificity, and institutional credibility, and older or generic pages were avoided unless they provided enduring legal or methodological context. Where accessible public material was insufficient, particularly for some paid market-research detail, the report flagged the gap rather than inventing precision, and recommended further paid diligence before final investment approval.[100]
 (<https://www.euromonitor.com/retail-in-ireland/report#:~:text=Understand%20the%20latest%20market,and%20Footwear%20Specialist%20E-Commerce>) [285](<https://www.psr.ie/psra-registers/commercial-leases-register/>) [280]
 (https://assets.cushmanwakefield.com/-/media/cw/marketbeat-pdfs/2025/q2/emea/ireland-retail-marketbeat_q2-2025.pdf?rev=340cf2f1cda64f8e82974126e1671084)



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